

SCHOOL DROPOUT IN CAMBODIA



A CASE STUDY OF PHNOM PENH AND KAMPONG SPEU

RESEARCH REPORT ■ JUNE 2016



KOICA

Research Report

**School Dropout in Cambodia: A Case Study of Phnom Penh and
Kompong Speu**

**Submitted to
Korea International Cooperation Agency (KOICA)
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Acknowledgements

KOICA Education section and RUPP Faculty of Education jointly conducted the exploratory research on school dropout in Cambodia. Two teams started discussions on cooperation in education sector in December 2015 and at last we grabbed this report a result of the hardworking for the last 4 months. Although there are some limitations of the research this report throws some light on dropout issues with wider aspects. It compared the dropouts in rural and urban areas and examining the possible determinants of it.

Currently, compared to the dire figures of drop-out of Cambodia, school dropout issues have not been fully explored nor understood by researchers as well as by education practitioners. Recognizing the increasing importance of dropout issues and its negative implications in improving human resource development of Cambodia, which is one of top policy priority agendas of Cambodian government, KOICA Cambodia Office paid attention to and decided to delve into the dropout cases and its surrounding environments.

For decades, Cambodia has achieved the astonishing progress in education development. It almost reached the universal primary education as well as met the gender parity target in primary education. However, inefficiency in the education system remains high, which is one of the impediments to furthering education development. Dropout is a widespread and common symptom in Cambodia. It stretched out to both rural and urban schools regardless of girls or boys. In terms of the determinants of drop-out, not only are the socio-economic status (SES) factors but also geographical, cultural, school characteristics are influential to some extent.

The complexities of the nature of drop-outs make it harder to understand how to reduce and address the drop outs in Cambodia. That being so, KOICA initiated this research examining the nature of school dropouts in an attempt to support Cambodian government in developing its education policy at the same time, to make use of it in KOICA's future assistance programs.

Despite the difficulties during the research, RUPP research team has successfully completed its missions and brought the valuable findings to those who are willing to support Cambodia education sector.

I would like to thank all who helped and involved this research activities, especially the RUPP FoE Dean Dr. Sok Soth for his unique sense of humor, which always reinvigorated the whole team members.

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RUPP Faculty of Education

Abbreviations

EFA	Education for All
KOICA	Korea International Cooperation Agency
MoEYS	Ministry of Education, Youth and Sports
NGOs	Non-Government Organizations
SDG	Sustainable Development Goal
UNESCO	United Nations Educational, Scientific, and Cultural Organization
USAID	The United States Agency for International Development
WB	World Bank

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Executive Summary

Introduction and context

Cambodia has achieved significant progresses in primary education (Tandon & Fukao, 2015; Overseas Development Institute, 2010). The net enrollment in primary education increased remarkably from 88.9 % in 2002 to 97 % in 2013 (although it dropped slightly to 95.6 % in 2014). In the same period, net enrollment in rural schools increased almost by 10 % from 90.3 % in 2002 to 98.4 % in 2014, the increase representing progress in achieving equitable access to primary education. Reducing gender disparity has also been a notable improvement in primary schools, with 93.65 % of school-aged girls reportedly being in school. This progress in access to education has been attributed to various interventions by the government, the MoEYS, NGOs and development partners in building schools, providing scholarships and breakfast programs, promoting community participation in education, training teachers, and improving school facilities and child-friendliness.

Nonetheless, the inefficiency in education system is still considerably high. Despite significant success in almost achieving the EFA goals in terms of the promotion of access to students, school dropout has remained unsolved. Although several efforts at different levels and from various international NGOs and development partners (UNESCO, WB, etc.) have been made to address this issue over the past few decades, the dropout rate has not changed substantially, with primary education stagnating at about 10 % and lower secondary education at about 20 %. This shows that Cambodia still has a mounting task to attract students, especially girls and rural students, to stay in school. A better understanding of how and why students drop out of school is thus needed in order to improve student completion rate.

Objectives

The current study comprised the following objectives:

1. To identify the characteristics and demographic profiles of dropout students and non-dropout students.
2. To examine factors contributing to school dropout.
3. To explore whether the nature of dropouts (characteristics, demographic profiles, and causes) is different by urban-rural divide.

Research methodology

The present study employed a mixed methods approach through integrating quantitative and qualitative methods within a single study to obtain a better understanding of the complexity of research inquiry for school dropouts. The goals of the quantitative method were to develop a set of items for answering the proposed research questions. The contents of the questionnaire items were based on a bulk of literature of school dropout. The qualitative method included semi-structured interviews, field notes, observations, and visual aids, with its goals to examine the participants' experiences, opinions, and feelings on school dropouts.

Eight lower secondary schools were chosen based on their high dropout rates. Four schools were located in Phnom Penh outskirt including Chambok Meas, Chamroeun Cheat, Prek Reang and Kong Noy. Four others scattered throughout Kampong Speu comprising Chhay Chhop, Beong Khna,

Chha-en, Teap Mean, two were located around town while the other two in a rather remote location.

Participants in this survey included 238 non-dropout students from grades 8 and 9 and 63 students who dropped out in the previous academic year (2014-2015) and 60 parents of dropout students. Non-dropout students were randomly selected from each school for the survey questionnaire based on a proportion of 50 % as the selection criterion. Thus, about 30 students (from two classes) were selected from each school for the survey. As for dropout students, given the high dropout rate at the secondary education level in Cambodia (approximately 20 %), 7 or 8 dropout students were selected from each school for the survey questionnaire through the assistance of the school directors or commune chiefs. The school principals made invitations before the visit of the research team. Dropout students and their parents were invited to come to school if their time allowed; otherwise, the research team approached each family at their house. During the field visit, the research team also conducted informal interviews with school principals and teachers to gain a holistic narrative of school dropout in their area.

Research findings

From the quantitative data

Based on the quantitative data, various characteristics were found to be contributing to school dropout. They included a wide range of issues from the low academic achievement to the lack of emotional attachment or a sense of belonging to school, to parents' lower educational background and aspiration, to lack of homeschooling or guidance/support from parents to students, to big family size, to arguably low value to education, to dropout history in the family, to child labor and to domestic violence. Late entry, low self-esteem, lack of preschool experience, low educational aspiration, undesired attitude toward school, absences from school and low commitment to doing homework all one way or another account for varied characteristics of dropout and non-dropouts. The study also found obvious evidence linking to community factors such as youth's low literacy in the community, risks and insecurity due to the use of drug (marijuana), and the lack of student enrollment campaign and dropout prevention within both urban and rural community.

From the qualitative data

From the qualitative data, two other school factors could be identified—location and school support. Those schools located near economically thriving town or city saw significant number of dropouts quitting school to help their families earned better living. Whether their family was already in a better off position in terms of assets and materials was not a determining factor to make the students stay in school. As a result, some dropouts were from quite sufficient families compared with many who continued to stay in school. Besides school location, school support, or rather the lack of it, was also a factor that contributing to the dropouts found in this study. School principals and teachers had put little, if at all, effort in finding out the cause that made the students quit school. There was also a lack of mechanism to attract these students back to school. Many school principals and teachers appeared to feel that their roles were to provide the education and the students roles were to decide whether or not to come or stay in school.

Family factor can also be divided into two smaller streams—the parents' level of education and their socio-economic status. Many of the dropouts were from families whose parents themselves had very little education. Although the parents acknowledged the importance of education, this

acknowledgement was not concrete enough to see significant influences on their children's staying in school. Many parents even expected the schools, particularly the teachers, to do more to make their children see the usefulness of staying in school. From the children's perspectives, it was hard for them to remain in school seeing that their parents could nonetheless make a living even with little education. Also concern with the parents, children could as well quit school because they could not tolerate seeing how hard their parents work in order to make a living. For those who were already better, it was the desire to move up the scale of plentiful living and materialism that made them drop out of schools.

Age was yet another factor that contributed to the dropout in this study. When students were young, they were of little help at home. For many, they were even burdens for their parents hindering their full potential of going away from home regularly to earn a living. Sending them to school was therefore a good choice as they could get their children educated while freeing themselves some time to make a living. This changed, however, when these children reached grade secondary school. At around 16 and 18 years of ages, these young students were of great help for the family. They could look after their younger siblings, sick or old family members, or help their families make a living if not other household chores. As a result, those who faced unsupportive conditions in their families had no choices but quit school. This was common in those eight schools examined in this study.

Finally, it was community factors that contributed to the dropout. There was little community support and awareness of the issues of dropout. Village and commune chiefs thought that it was the responsibilities of both the students' families and the schools to make them stay in schools. Students and their families were not made aware of the importance of literacy in their everyday lives. Radios and TV programs did very little to raise this awareness as well. In remote schools, the lack of evidence of how literacy can impact lives for better made students see no reasons for studying. Although there were some scholarships given to underprivileged students, these scholarships were hardly enough. A girl who dropped out from Chamroeun Cheat stated that she could make at least 10,000 Riel (2.5US\$) per day if stayed home and helped her parents sell porridges and soft drinks at homes while her parents were out making more money. This made the government scholarships of around 50\$ per year highly insignificant to motivate them to stay in school.

Comparative case studies

This study concluded that the nature of school dropout was geographically different to the extent that might be inconceivable without unlocking these comparative case studies. While poverty, job opportunity (generating more family income), and the need for domestic and care work were commonplace in both locations, factors including the lack of religious schools, family mobility, insecurity surrounding school, incomplete schools, repeated absence, low academic achievement, private fee at school, and debt due to land business compound the impact on city children to quit school or their parents' decision to pull them out of school.

Some appealing factors that might not be the case in the city were, however, manifested in the rural schools. The findings of this study point to a conclusion that in rural areas, peer pressure, lack of value to education among parents, low literacy among parents and youth, little job opportunities, and debt due to repeated marriage of their children all represented as the pullout factors relating to school dropout. Apparently, apart from the vicious poverty constraint, in rural

areas community influences affected the values to education greatly, thereby thwarting local people's aspiration to invest in the education of their children, especially girls.

Recommendations

Based on the findings of the current study, a number of recommendations are provided to reduce dropout, particularly for at-risk students as the following:

1. School and community support mechanisms to inform students and their families of importance of staying in school.
 - a. Schools should actively identify which students are vulnerable to dropout and take immediate affirmative actions when students are showing signs of dropout.
 - b. Communities should have a literacy campaign to raise awareness of K-12 education.
2. Higher scholarships and better support for students from poor families.
3. Teachers should have a place they can stay in or near the school if they have to travel far from their home to teach. This was particularly important for female teachers.
 - a. They should have incentives for teaching in challenging and/or remote areas.
 - b. Their teaching should be monitored closely to make sure the students are not forced to pay informal fees or other bribes.
4. Schools in rural locations or in insecure places should have a mechanism to transport students back and forth to school. Lunch should also be provided and extra-curriculum activities should be provided to engage the students in a more practical level.
5. MoEYS should ensure there is at least one complete school in the community, especially when the next level school (upper secondary school) is far away from the current school in which students are currently enrolled.
6. MoEYS should ensure schools have Muslim and/or ethnic teachers to teach students from different religious or cultural backgrounds.
7. The counseling program should be established in each school to promote and enhance student learning by means of helping them dealing with their personal and emotional problems that can affect their studies.
8. Job providers, including factories, should strictly follow the age limitation for work in their factories.
 - a. Local authorities like village and commune chiefs should strictly follow the regulations. They should not issue fake or modified work paper allowing underage students to be employed in the factories.
 - b. Local job providers should be encouraged to prioritize giving employment to students who study and work part-time, not the dropout.

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1. Introduction

Over the last few decades, the world has paid serious attention to improving equitable access of children to high quality education. The most manifested commitment to this cause is the global flagship initiative “Education For All” (EFA). The EFA was established in 1990 under the Jomtien Framework, Thailand, with a main aim of providing all the global citizens equal access to high quality education. With this initiative, countries worldwide are struggling to improve student enrollment rate to ensure everyone has equal rights to quality nine-year basic education. Since then, much progress has been realized. However, EFA has yet to be fully achieved as planned and was then revisited in Senegal in 2000, the meeting that culminated into the Dakar Framework for Action.

Along with the EFA, all the countries in the world have been working to meet the goals set in the Millennium Development Goals by 2015. Cambodia is no exception. The Constitution of Cambodia and the Education Law¹ promulgate a strong commitment to providing compulsory basic education² to all children regardless of gender, social or physical status, and ethnic background. Providing free, equitable access to quality basic education (grades 1-9) has, in particular, become a vital strategy of the Royal Government of Cambodia in reviving the country’s education system and in achieving the EFA goals, particularly Goal 2, and now Sustainable Development Goal (SDG) target 4.1. The 1993 National Constitution, for example, recognizes the right to education for all with the State responsible to “protect and update citizens’ rights to quality education at all levels.” The Education Law, promulgated in December 2007, stipulates that every citizen has the right to access free, quality education of at least nine years’ duration in public schools.³

From that commitment, Cambodia has achieved significant progresses in primary education (Tandon & Fukao, 2015; Overseas Development Institute, 2010). The net enrollment in primary education increased remarkably from 88.9 % in 2002 to 97 % in 2013 (although it dropped slightly to 95.6 % in 2014). In the same period, net enrollment in rural schools increased almost by 10 % from 90.3 % in 2002 to 98.4 % in 2014, the increase representing progress in achieving equitable access to primary education. Reducing gender disparity has also been a notable improvement in primary schools, with 93.65 % of school-aged girls reportedly being in school. This progress in access to education has been attributed to various interventions by the government, the MoEYS, NGOs and development partners in building schools, providing scholarships and breakfast programs, promoting community participation in education, training teachers, and improving school facilities and child-friendliness.

Through this progress, it is definitely apparent that the education situation in Cambodia has been enjoying great success in meeting the Education for All goals in its attempt to reduce illiteracy. Nonetheless, another challenge has transpired behind this seemingly successful episode. The inefficiency in education system is still considerably high, which becomes the main impediment to educational development. Despite significant success in almost achieving the EFA goals in terms of the promotion of access to students, school dropout has remained unsolved. The country has been experiencing a large number of school dropouts for a number of years. In other words, many children who have entered primary schools cannot finish the grades successfully. The average dropout rate for each grade in primary school level was 8.7 % and the percentage increased more

¹ Cambodian Education Law (2007)

² Education for All National Plan 2003-2015

³ UNESCO-IBE (2011), World Data on Education 2010/2011

than two-fold to 19.6 % in lower-secondary school level (MoEYS, 2011; USAID, 2016). Although several efforts at different levels and from various international NGOs and development partners (UNESCO, WB, etc.) have been made to address this issue over the past few decades, the dropout rate has not changed substantially, with primary education stagnating at about 10 % and lower secondary education at about 20 %, and the rates vary significantly across regions (MoEYS, 2014). At the same time, dropouts appear to have geographical discrimination aspects. Dropouts are more likely to happen in a rural area than in an urban area (Nou, 2015). This shows that Cambodia still has a mounting task to attract students, especially girls, to stay in school. This challenge desperately calls for effective intervention strategies from both policy makers and practitioners in the education sector. A better understanding of how and why students drop out of school is needed in order to improve student completion rate.

1.1. Research objectives

To address the aforementioned problems, the research team proposes the following generic research objectives.

1. To identify the characteristics and demographic profiles of dropout students and non-dropout students.
2. To examine factors contributing to school dropout.
3. To explore whether the nature of dropouts (characteristics, demographic profiles, and causes) is different by urban-rural divide.

1.2. Research questions

1. What are the characteristics and demographic profiles of dropout students and non-dropout students?
2. What factors are contributing to school dropout?
3. Is the nature of school dropout different in urban and rural areas?

2. Context of school dropout in Cambodia

The dropout phenomenon is not new, nor does it exist only in Cambodia. Many other countries have also been struggling to deal with this issue. In attempts to tackle this dropout problem, a great deal of research has been conducted to understand the causes of school abandonment. Ban and Kim (2015), in their review of literature for their research project categorized dropout factors into four groups: (1) student factors (gender, ethnic, racial, peer context characteristics, student performance, attitude, behaviors and background), (2) family factors (family size, poverty, parents' education and so forth), (3) school factors (school quality, curriculum, school regulation and teacher quality), and (4) regional, community, and country factors (urban and rural area, the distance from school to student's house, local infrastructure and others).

Research on dropout has also been a prominent topic in Cambodia, too. In Keng's (2005) study, which was conducted in two rural villages of Pursat province, the reason why students decided to drop out was because their parents were illiterate and they had to work to help earn an income for the family. No and Hirakawa (2012) conducted a study on a total of 868 students from first, fourth and seventh grades in five primary schools and five lower secondary schools in Kampong Cham Province and found that being overage, poor academic achievement, ethnicity, and having parents with low aspiration on education were the main dropout factors. However, the study did

not find the school factors to be significantly influential enough. A subsequent study, building on No and Hirakawa's (2012) study, found significance in some of all the four dropout factor categories: student, school, family, and regional, community, and country factors (Ang, No, Soeung, & Hirakawa, 2014). Repetition, mother's education, loss of parent/parents, teacher's absence, and parent living far away all contributed to students' decision to drop out.

In a separate study by Creative Associates International (2014), funded by USAIDS, the reasons for dropping out among students in grades 7-9 in some districts in Banteay Meanchey, Battambang, Kampong Speu, Prey Veng, Pursat, and Svay Rieng were classified into two main categories: (1) economic reasons and (2) academic and school-related reasons. About 70% of the students participating in the research reported that they dropped out or were likely to drop out because they had to help with household chores and family business, about 50% had to work to earn money, and about 40% said they could not pay school-related expenses. Only a small percentage of students (20% for each factor) mentioned the reason of academic performance for their dropping out. Also from the study, some teacher factors were mentioned as the reason for students to drop out. "Teacher does not think I am/was intelligent" was reported by 30% of the students, "Teacher treats some students better than others" by 31%, and "Criticizing students for wrong answers" by 28%. Regarding students' own engagement in school, this study reported that 35% of the target students spent less than 1 hour on homework each night, 33% rarely or never completed required homework, 24% were bullied or picked on, and 20% thought that school was not fun.

The study by Creative Associate International also reported on absenteeism among the target students. Twenty four percent of dropouts reported to have been absent for more than 2 days a month, while 34% were absent more than 15 consecutive days. Thirty five percent of students in the study who were at risk of dropping out reported to be absent for more than 2 days a month, whereas 56% were absent for more than 15 consecutive days.

3. School dropout literature

There are several kinds of theoretical perspectives, including psychological, behaviorist, societal, interactional, economic, organizational, etc., that were developed to study a complex nature of school dropout. These perspectives have shed light on the evolutionary process of this educational problem at various levels where the problem is nested. The section that follows describes problems at each level in a great detail.

3.1. Individual level

3.1.1. Student background

Student background has been widely documented to play a vital role in determining school retention and dropout. Usually, students who possess some kinds of unchangeable backgrounds are at risk of ending their educational careers early. Of many student background characteristics, gender and races are of particular emphasis among educational inequality theorists. Generally, they found that girls tended to stay in school shorter than boys (Diyu, 2002; Holmes, 2003; Odaga & Heneveld, 1995). From birth, in some societies, people value education of boys more than that of girls, given that girls are believed to serve their future husbands' family welfares after being married off. Very little empirical evidence showed that girls retained in schooling longer than boys (Mansory, 2007; Open Society Institute [OUI], 2007). In Mongolia, boys help raise their family

incomes better than do girls (UNICEF, 2005). It was also proved that students from minority groups were more vulnerable to leaving school earlier than their counterparts from the majority groups (Chatterji & DeSimone, 2005; Laird et al., 2007; Roebuck et al., 2004). This is due to minority groups usually residing in rural or remote parts of a country where education-required job availability and public funding are not so high.

More predictors on the student background domain were cited continually, such age at school entry, preschool experience and poor health condition. By and large, students who were overage for their grades were shown to be at the greater risk of dropping out (Lloyd, Mensch & Clark, 2000; Wils, 2004). In its study on out-of-school children in 15 countries, UNESCO (2005) found out that in nine countries, the majority of children left school when they were three or more years older than the expected ending age for primary school education. Generally, those late entrants found themselves difficult in socializing with their young classmates. The opportunity costs of schooling also became large when students entered school late, the factor luring students to the world of work. Next, in studies on dropout, preschool experience is also often related. Literature has shown that children who participated in preschool tended to have high completion rates (Barnett, 1995; Reynold et al., 2007). Preschool experience did not only reduce dropout rates but also positively influenced later school performance and well-being of children. Another critical factor is a health condition of the children. As previous research has indicated, children who have poor health conditions possess high possibility of leaving school earlier (OUI, 2007).

3.1.2. Academic performance

In this sub-domain, there are two important predictors: grade repetition and academic achievement. A number of studies found that children with a higher achievement were more likely to attend school and survived longer in their educational careers (Abrams & Haney, 2004; Bedi & Marshall, 2002; Jimerson et al., 2005; King, Orazem & Paterno, 2008). In New Zealand, Maani and Kalb (2005) convinced that any policy that could improve the academic performance of students by one point of a grade would reduce dropout rates by 4.3 percent. Another main determinant is grade retention. But evidence was somewhat mixed. While the vast literature shows that grade retention or repetition reduced the likelihood of children's schooling continuation (Andre, 2008; King, Orazem & Paterno, 2008; UNESCO, 2005), more precisely increasing dropout rates as much as 20-30 percent after controlling for other potential predictors (Grisson & Shepard, 1989), in Chicago, testing-based promotion policy that increased repetition rate of eight-graders from 1% to 10% actually lowered later dropout rates (Allensworth, 2004). The study concluded that repetition effectively prepared students for the next grade and raised their achievement in latter grades.

3.1.3. Behavioral factors

Behaviorists have argued that it is important to observe some misbehavior activities of children since they can inform educational stakeholders of who are at risk of dropping out. Usually, students who were involved in delinquency activities (Chavez & Oetting, 1994; Natriello, 2002) and substance abuse (Farahati et al., 2003; Roebuck et al., 2004; Chatterji & DeSimone, 2005; TEA, 2006) tended to end their educational careers earlier than the normal students. Practically, such misbehavior activities occur at higher grades of schooling, particularly at the high school level. At school or classroom level, teachers or principals can observe two detrimental behaviors that signal the onset of dropout. Much research proved that students who had low class attendance would become less interested in schooling and dropout would be the ending school pathway (Bridgeland

et al., 2006; Kennelly & Monrad, 2007; OUI, 2007). Rumberger and Lim (2008) in their review of dropout research in the last 25 years reconfirmed that students who were less involved in class participation, such as homework completion, were at a greater risk of dropping-out.

Social scientists consistently stated that adolescent behaviors were more influenced by their peers than any other socialization institutions. Youngsters whose friends had already dropped out and engaged in any income-generating work were more likely to drop out of school (OUI, 2007). In their longitudinal study using data from the National Longitudinal Study of Adolescent Health in America, Staff and Kreager (2008) found that boys with high status in violent groups were at much greater risks of high school dropouts than other students (also Evans, Oates & Schwab, 1992; French & Conrad, 2001).

Much literature in developing country contexts often proved a positive relationship between amount of time that students worked to help their families and high dropout rates (Bickel & Pagaianis, 1988; OUI, 2007; Rumberger, 1983). Some researchers even set a clear threshold of its detrimental effect, for example, over 14 hours a week by Mann (1989), or 20 hours a week by Winters (1986) (as cited in Mike et al., 2008). Working for some hours could help funding their schooling because costs of schooling were often reported as the main obstacle for students to progress beyond a certain point of schooling (Cardoso & Verner, 2006).

3.1.4. Psychological factors

From a psychological perspective, high dropout rates were strongly correlated with low educational aspiration (St. John & Starkey, 1995), low self-esteem and low motivation (Finn, 1989; Natriello, 2002; Bridgeland, 2006; OUI, 2007). Generally students with high learning motivation and education goals tended to have high level of self-regulation to achieve their set goals (Hidi & Harackiewicz, 2000). Student motivation level was mainly increased in school setting by their teachers' care, professional enthusiasm, interesting teaching methodology, and stimulating classroom environment (Cothran & Ennis, 2000). However, according to Hammer (2003), home environment also plays a crucial role in shaping motivation of a child. Positive parental encouragement and involvement in their children's education could raise their children's intrinsic and extrinsic motivation.

3.2. Family level

3.2.1. Family structures

Family structures and mobility influenced the rates of dropout in several ways. It was a commonplace that a student who lived under the same roof with their biological parents had a high schooling survival rate than that whose parents passed away, got divorced or moved to work in other areas (Nicaise, Tonguthai & Fripont, 2000). Next, a large family size meant less learning opportunity for each of its household members and its influence became much stronger for older siblings (Nicaiso, Tonguthai & Fripont, 2000; Rosati & Rossi, 2003). However, some studies (e.g. Chernichovsky, 1985; Gome, 1984; Mike et al., 2008) found out that children in larger households were less likely to drop out.

3.2.2. Family resources

It is widely believed that low socio-economic status of a family adversely influences dropout. A survey conducted by Open Society Institute in 2007 in six developing countries found that low economic status of a family was the prominent reason for education withdrawal. This finding was consistent with many other studies in different settings, such as in Brazil by Cardoso and Verner (2006), in China by Diyu (2002); in Thailand by Nicaise, *et al.* (2000) just to name a few. Regardless of contextual areas, the students whose parents were highly educated tended to stay in school longer (Beherman et al., 2000; Mike et al., 2008; Swada & Lokshin, 2001). More specifically, Holmes (2003) found that education attainment of a father increased the expected level of school retention of boys, while the education of a mother enhanced girls' schooling in Pakistan.

Having experienced a birth of an unwanted child and a sudden loss in remittance in the past six years that increase a high level of financial instability in a family also increases the likelihood of dropout (Lloyd, Mete & Grant, 2006). Cardoso and Verner (2006) suggested that when a father suddenly became unemployed, his children tended to drop out of school earlier in order to engage in income-generating jobs to help relieve family's financial burdens. Besides, a number of researchers ascertained that the economic crisis drastically changed the household patterns and then created high dropout possibility (e.g., Thomas et al., 2004; Smith & Thomas, 2003; Behrman et al., 2000). It was clear evident that a sudden change in family resources would ignite high dropout.

3.2.3. Family practices

The students whose parents monitor and regulate their schooling activities, provide emotional support, encourage independent decisionmaking and are involved in their schooling are less likely to drop out of school (Astone & McLanalan, 1991; Rumber, 1995; Odaga & Heneveld, 1995; Rumberger et al., 1990). The motivation levels of the parents with higher educational attainment were found higher than those with lower attainment. The paucity of professional role model in their community hindered their imagination of education value, which resulted in devaluation of education for their children (Nicaise, Tonguthai & Fripont, 2000). The studies in America also revealed similar results (e.g. Natriello, 2002).

3.3. School level

Organizational theories claimed that behaviors and nature of people in an organization and behavior and nature of an organization *per se* contributed to high dropout rates (Chen, in press). Typically, good school quality, a term that covers most aspects of school factors, ranging from facilities to teaching staff and school management, could lead to low dropout and high completion rates (Hanushek, 2008; Hanushek & Lavy, 1994; Lloyd, Tawila, Clark & Mensch, 2003). The good quality school, in a long run, provided children with not only high rates of return to education but also many other social returns, such as low infant and child mortality, better child health and education, lower fertility, less crime, and so on. In some studies, the students in small schools were found to be less likely to drop out than their counterparts in large schools (Werblow, 2009). The finding suggested that a quintile increase in school size was associated with a 12 percent increase in average student dropout rate in American high schools.

At the teacher level, a number of teacher characteristics could also lead to low retention of their students. First, teachers with low educational and pedagogical knowledge produced unproductive

and less interesting teaching methods, which made students attend classes irregularly and had low academic achievement, as a result (Diyu, 2002). Parents became discouraged from further investing in their children schooling. The most cited of all are teachers' motivation and absenteeism (Chaudhury et al., 2004; Nicaise, Tonguthai & Fripont, 2000). Low professional motivation and high absenteeism resulted from low financial incentives, poor working conditions, inadequate career opportunities, and poor supportive service. A few studies investigated teachers' origins and dropout rates, and they found that a school where most teachers resided in that community had low dropout rates (Lloyd et al., 2006). OUI (2007) further reported that the teachers and schools who had negative, punitive and repressive attitudes towards slow learners and irregular-attending students pushed many students out of school.

3.4. Community and government level

At the community level, a set of arguments has gained attention of researchers who studied relationship between community characteristics and dropout. Russel (2001) claimed that communities could influence dropout rates by providing employment opportunities during school (also Bickel & Pagainnis, 1988; Rumberger, 1983). Also, cultural influences were significantly attested as a variable explaining dropout decision. Low support from school community was one of the main determinants in predicting high dropout rates (Natriello, 2002). Living in a more developed community was an important and statistically significant factor in reducing the chance of dropout of rural Pakistani children (Lloyd, Mete, & Grant, 2006).

Why many children are not in school can also be explained by the negative impacts of some supply-side predictors. When students needed to travel a long commute because of low availability of schools, dropping-out at a certain grade was inevitable (Lloyd, Mete & Sathar, 2005; Mike et al., 2008; OUI, 2007). Even a shortage of post-primary schools in a community was an important factor holding down enrollment in primary school and promoting early dropouts (Lavy, 1996). Another possible cause of school dropout was the deficiency in the link between education and the needs of local labor market (Nicaise, Tonguthai, & Fripont, 2000; Natriello, 2002). If young people from agricultural areas had to go through a curriculum which was too academically oriented for them, they would become alienated from their surroundings. The fear of being alienated forced them to deny formal schooling.

4. Research methodology

4.1. Research design

The present study employed a mixed methods approach through integrating quantitative and qualitative methods within a single study to obtain a better understanding of the complexity of research inquiry for school dropouts. A mixed methods approach was chosen, as either quantitative or qualitative methods were not adequate in providing an in-depth understanding into the complexities of school dropouts. The use of mixed methods complements the strengths and weaknesses of quantitative and qualitative methods.

The current study used a sequential explanatory design comprising two distinct phases. The quantitative phase comprised survey questionnaires. The goals of the quantitative phase were to develop a set of items for answering the proposed research questions. The contents of the questionnaire items were based on a bulk of literature of school dropout. The qualitative phase included semi-structured interviews, field notes, observations, and visual aids. The goals of the

qualitative phase were to examine the participants' experiences, opinions, and feelings on school dropouts.

4.2. Sampling and sample

To explore the various reasons for secondary school dropouts, eight schools were chosen based on their high dropout rates. Four schools were located in Phnom Penh outskirts including Chambok Meas, Chamroeun Cheat, Prek Reang and Kong Noy. Four others scattered throughout Kampong Speu comprising Chhay Chhop, Beong Khna, Chha-en, Teap Mean, two were located around town while the other two in a rather remote location. Participants in this survey included 238 non-dropout students from grades 8 and 9 and 63 students who dropped out in the previous academic year (2014-2015) and 60 parents of dropout students.

Non-dropout students were randomly selected from each school for the survey questionnaire based on a proportion of 50 % as the selection criterion. Thus, about 30 students (from two classes) were selected from each school for the survey. Dropout students were those enrolled in a given grade at a given school year who are no longer enrolled in the following school⁴. Given the high dropout rate at the secondary education level in Cambodia (approximately 20 %), 7 or 8 dropout students were selected from each school for the survey questionnaire through the assistance of the school directors or commune chiefs. The school principals made invitations before the visit of the research team. Dropout students and their parents were invited to come to school if their time allowed; otherwise, the research team approached each family at their house. During the field visit, the research team also conducted informal interviews with school principals and teachers to gain a holistic narrative of school dropout in their area. Table 1 describes the key characteristics of the dropouts and non-dropouts.

Table 1: Sample characteristics

		Dropout		Non-dropout	
		N	%	N	%
Gender	Male	25	39.7	102	42.9
	Female	38	60.3	136	57.1
	Total	63	100	238	100
Nationality	Khmer	45	71.4	180	75.9
	Chinese	0	0	0	0
	Muslim(Cham)	10	15.9	29	12.2
	Vietnamese	0	0	0	0
	SUY ethnic minority	8	12.7	28	11.9

4.3. Research tools

Three structured questionnaires were developed for non-dropouts, dropouts and dropouts' parents (see Appendixes). The design of these questionnaires was consulted with a few school departure theories (see the literature review) and other practical factors grounded in the previous

⁴ Source: UNESCO Institute for Statistics, Technical Guidelines, (2009)

dropout studies in Cambodia including social, economic, cultural, individual and school factors. The validity of the questionnaire was examined through a consultative meeting with KOICA and piloted with school directors, teachers and students in one suburban school in the city and at the field site.

4.4. Data collection

In each area (urban and rural), two districts were purposively selected with reference to the dropout rate reported in the data collected by the Ministry of Education, Youth and Sport. The fieldwork protocol was sent to the Provincial Office of Education for permission. School directors were contacted and consulted as core informants about how data of dropout students could be approached for the survey questionnaire and the semi-structured interview. Alternatively, the commune chiefs were contacted for assistance in making an appointment for the survey questionnaire and the semi-structured interview with dropout students and their parents, school principals and teachers. All data was collected and treated with high ethical consideration. All participants were requested to sign a consent form before participating in this survey and were treated with great caution to protect their privacy. Any identity of the participants was thus not required in any form.

4.5. Data analysis

The quantitative data (survey questionnaires) were analyzed using SPSS focusing on the percentage, mean scores and some necessary statistics to test relationships or association (e.g., *t*-test, Chi-Square, etc.). Despite student and parent data were analyzed separately, constant comparison was made to provide a generic picture of factors linked to student departure from school. The qualitative data (i.e., interviews, observations, field notes, and visual aids) were analyzed using both descriptive and narrative approaches by means of dividing them into themes and characteristics to brief the contextual factors that could be related factors explaining student dropout in both grades. In sum, these data were discussed to draw an interactive framework for policy and practice, particularly for further research on student dropout in urban and rural Cambodia.

5. Findings and analysis

5.1. The quantitative findings

5.1.1. Characteristics of dropouts and non-dropouts

This section provides a comparative picture of characteristics of dropout and non-dropout students in Phnom Penh and Kompong Speu, as sampled for this current study, looking into the variations in student background, study behaviors, family factors, school factors, community factors, and the availability of scholarship/support. The significant testing tools (Chi-square and *t*-test) were used to analyze the survey questionnaire data accordingly, depending on the nature of each question, to determine if significant differences/associations were statistically evident, with a chosen significant level of 0.05 ($p < .05$). Due to the likely lengthy report, this section presents only the issues that were found statistically significant on the ground of the test of difference (*t*-test) and association (*Chi-square*). Other issues incorporated into the questionnaires but not reported here to a less extent accounted for differences in the characteristics of dropout and non-dropout

students, thus representing factors not strongly or significantly associated with school dropout. In the simplest terms, they were not the main causes of school dropout.

5.1.1.1. Student background

As specified in the questionnaire, a group of student background-related questions were asked to students with a purpose to document as to whether their demographic profiles could make a difference in a decision to stay in school or to drop out. A few outstanding facts were observed from this intent. Results from the analysis indicated that the likelihood of dropping out of school was not associated with students' gender and nationalities. There was no clear evidence that female students were the more likely dropout cohort, or vice versa. Dropouts appeared to be mixed by gender. This reveals that dropouts were not a unique issue between male and female students. The same evidence was found on the variation in dropouts by nationalities. This study found that ethnicity was not an influential factor, leading to school dropouts. Some instances were observed but they were not the significant cases among all the subjected selected.

Other student background factors were more evident, of which age and self-esteem were of much relevance. The study found that older students were more likely to drop out. So were students with lower self-esteem in school life. Table 2 shows that dropout students were two years older than their non-dropout peers. As for self-esteem, they appeared to be socially integrated and capable, but when it came to school life, their self-esteem was significantly lower. These findings reflect a critical issue of a late entry among dropout students and the lack of an academic support provided to them.

Table 2: Significant student backgrounds of dropout and non-dropout students

		Type of students	N	Mean	SD
Age		Non-dropout	238	14.93	1.29
		Dropout	63	16.33	1.82
Self-esteem	I can do things for daily life as well as the others can.	Non-dropout	235	2.07	0.68
		Dropout	63	1.87	0.73
	I can do things for social life as well as the others can.	Non-dropout	237	1.83	0.54
		Dropout	63	2.25	0.99

Note: Self-esteem was evaluated based on students' rating of the 5-point Likert scale provided to each question (i.e., 1=Strongly agree; 2=Agree; 3=Neutral/Don't Know; 4=Disagree; 5=Strongly disagree)

5.1.1.2. Study behaviors

An examination of study behaviors of dropout and non-dropout students has revealed some interesting features of school dropout issues in the context of this study. Among study behaviors questions observed, we found that dropout students tended to exhibit less desired attitude towards schooling, have no preschool experience, have lower educational aspiration, be more absent before dropping out, and miss homework more often.

When asked if they like going to school, the Chi-Square test showed a significant difference in their responses ($p < .05$), with dropout students more likely expressing lessened interest in going to school. As shown in the figure below, 13 per cent of dropout students appeared to reveal indifference to school; whereas, for non-dropouts, their indifference to school was almost undetectable. This finding, though apparently small in magnitude in terms of association, would cast meaningful light on students' divided attitude toward schooling, which might have various implications on their dropping out.

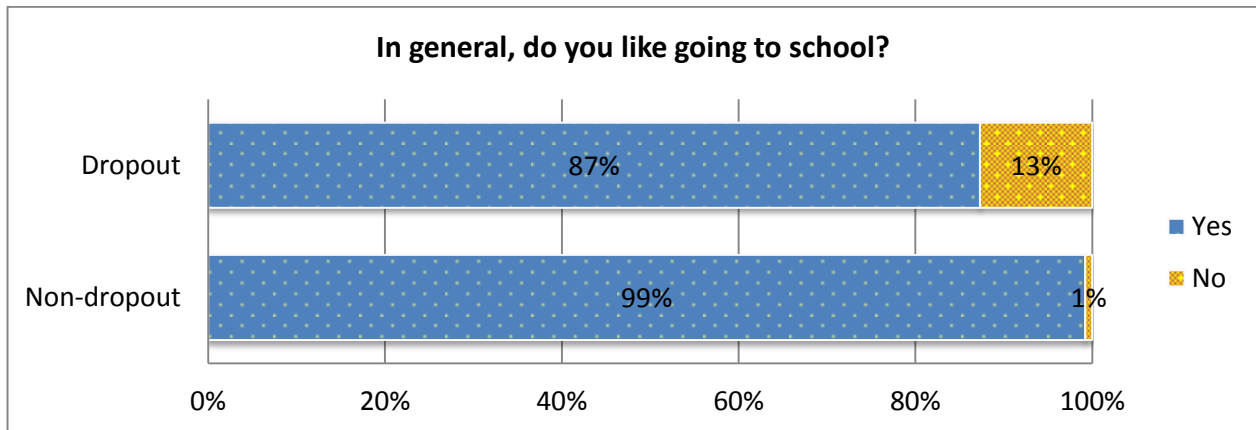


Figure 1: Attitude towards schooling

Having no pre-school experience was also a point of difference between dropouts and non-dropouts. The data showed that, within the dropout sample, there were a significantly higher number of students reported having never attended preschool before entering the first grade. For the non-dropout cohort, the rate of attending or not attending a kindergarten almost leveled, indicating that issue of school dropout is rather complex than what might have been thought. While this finding, for example, appears to highlight the importance of preschool experience in preparing students to be more socially and academically ready, the lack of preschool experience seems to have a less serious implication on all the students studied. This implies a bulk of related factors might push and pull students out of school rather than a mere preschool-experience.

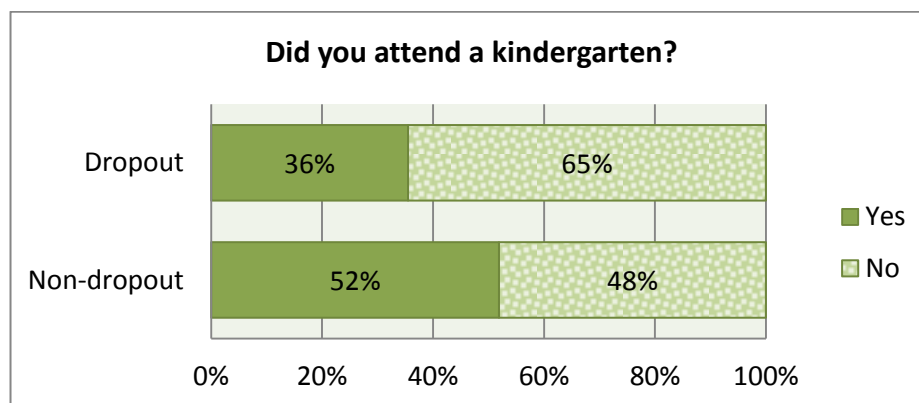


Figure 2: Preschool-experience

Another obvious behavior among dropout students was their lower educational aspiration. When asked how long/high they wish to stay in school, divided opinions were detected. We found that dropout students only wished to complete high school if they could. They appeared to set a lower bar for their education compared to their non-dropout counterpart who mostly dreamt to

complete the university or college degree. Such divided behaviors might affect their motivation to learn greatly although this study did not go into detail the impact on their motivation to learn. But, despite direct relationships were not observed, two likely impact indicators were found relating to dropout students' at-risk study behaviors such as more absences from class and failure to commit time and energy to doing homework.

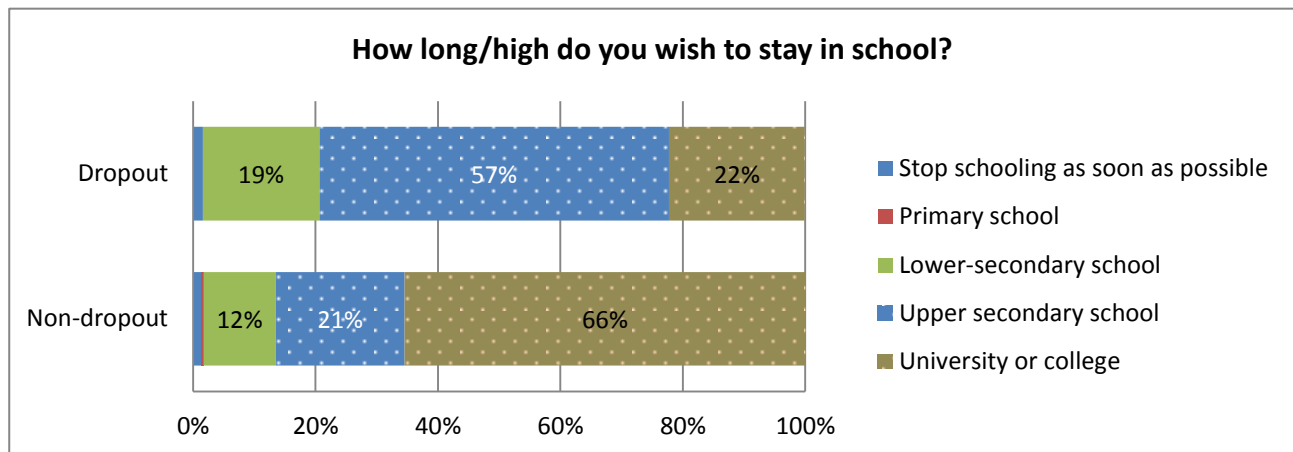


Figure 3: Educational aspiration

Overall, these findings were expected given that dropout is a process in which students' prerequisite characteristics were critical in determining their likelihood to depart from or stay in school. Lack of preschool experience could be a disadvantage that would one way or another result in various undesired behaviors in learning such as lack of motivation to learn, more absences, etc. The findings suggest that dropout students were likely to show at-risk behaviors in the first place which would be later exacerbated at home or at school, especially when support from teachers and schools was not fully attended to.

5.1.1.3. Family factors

Besides students' individual factors, a bulk of influences was attributed to the family factors. Data showed that there were certain disadvantaged family characteristics that might have influenced students' decision to quit school. Mostly, dropout students tended to have parents who had lower educational background and lower education aspiration. The result from this study demonstrated that parents of dropouts mostly had no more than primary education. The low academic background of parents could put students into a disadvantaged home environment. This can be reflected in their lower educational aspiration and other lack of homeschooling, which will be presented later.

Table 3: Parents' education of dropouts and non-dropout students

Parents' education	Education Level Completed	Dropout		Non-dropout	
		Father	Mother	Father	Mother
	Never attended school	16.1%	35.1%	3.8%	17.3%
	Primary school	50.0%	52.6%	39.7%	47.7%
	Lower secondary	16.9%	12.3%	33.8%	26.6%
	Upper secondary school	10.7%	0%	14.5%	4.6%
	University or college	3.6%	0%	8.1%	3.8%

This study found that dropout parents had significantly lower educational aspiration for their children. As can be seen in the table below, they likely expected their children to only finish high school at best; whereas parents of non-dropout students appeared to put a high bar on their children's education, expecting them to have a university degree. The education of the students' families seems to dictate the likelihood of student leaving school or staying in school to a great degree.

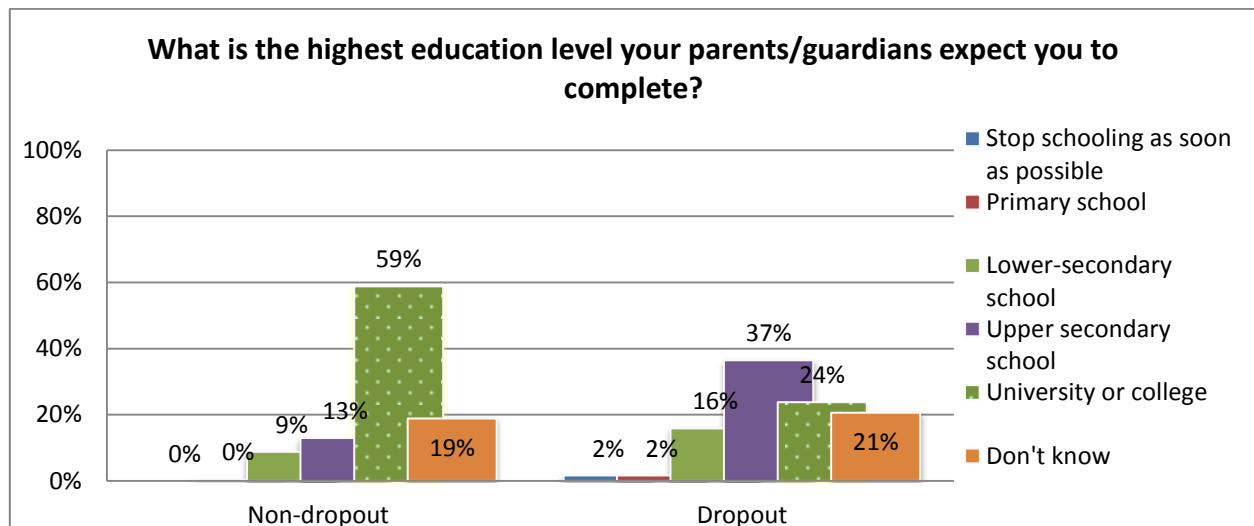


Figure 4: Parents' educational aspiration

When asked about their parents' role model at home, they appeared to have little guidance or support from their parents. We found that dropout students seemed to lack career guide from parents and to relevant education they should choose in life and home tutoring. Attention from parents to schooling or the value of education appeared to be missing among students who dropped out.

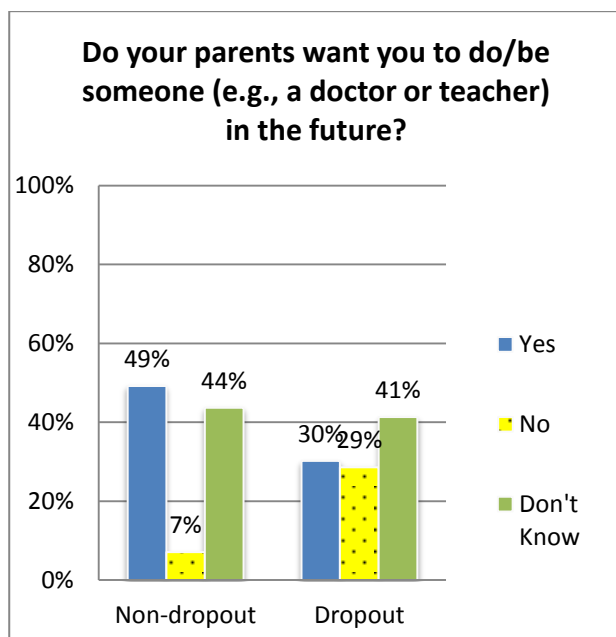


Figure 5: Career guide from parents

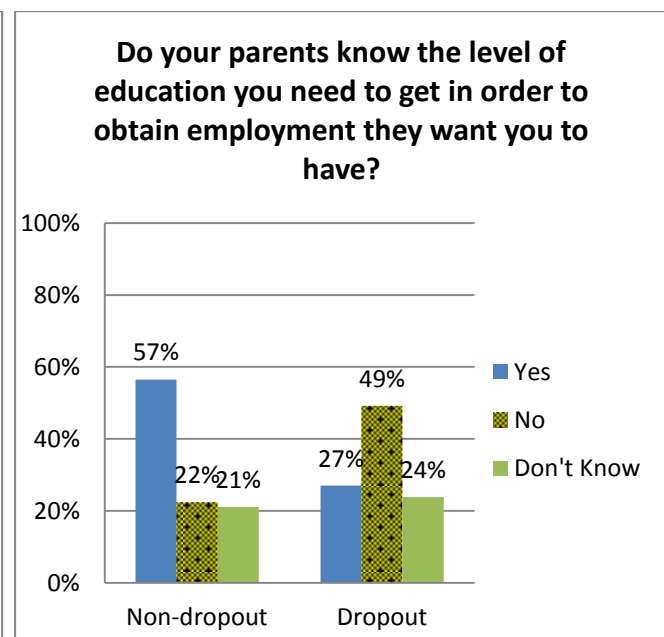


Figure 6: Relevance of education guided by parents

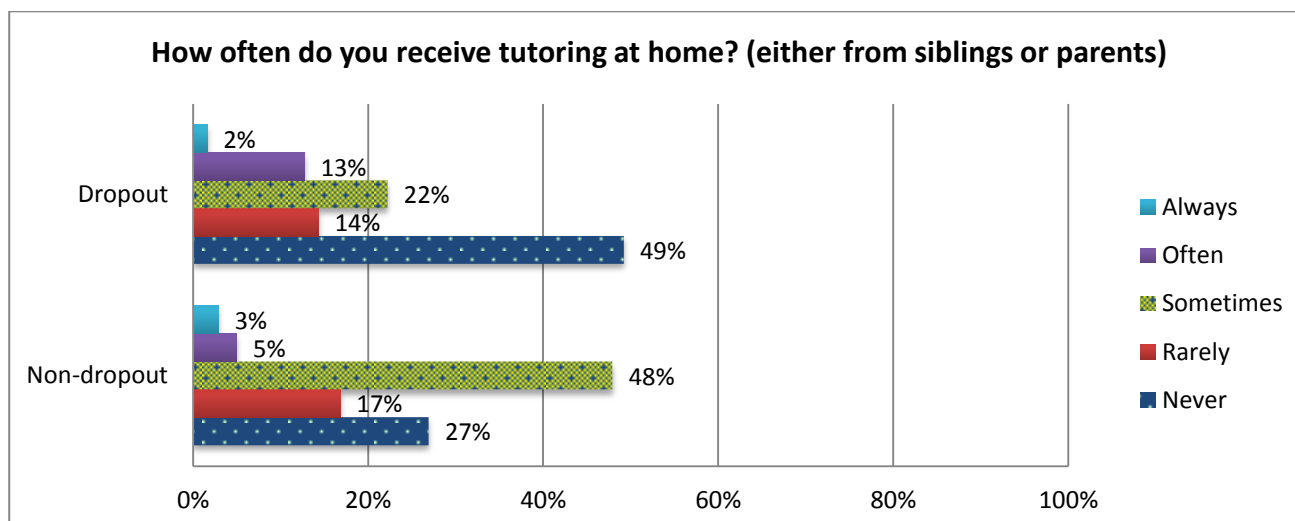


Figure 7: Home tutoring (either from sibling or parents)

On the socio-economic front, we found dropout students were from families that likely had no a motorbike and piped water, a basic socio-economic indicator. However, apparently poverty was not the main barrier to schooling in most cases. Based on the survey data, dropout students seemed to come from families with a higher income compared to their non-dropout peers. Data show that families of dropout students reportedly earned twice as much the amount of monthly income as that of non-dropout students (*families of non-dropout students = 1,519,411 Riels; families of dropout students = 700,065 Riels*). Value to education might be a related factor given that although they reportedly had parents who could earn higher income, their pocket money per day was more meager compared to their dropout peers (*pocket money for non-dropout students = 3,200 Riels; pocket money for dropout students = 2,400 Riels*). The higher income might otherwise be associated with more members of the family more committed to working for income generation than to schooling, leading students more prone to early departure from school.

Table 4: Significant socio-economic indicators of non-dropout and dropout students

Student Type	Home Possession	Yes	No
Non-Dropout	Motorbike	84.70%	15.30%
Dropout		71.40%	28.60%
Non-Dropout	Piped water	50.40%	49.60%
Dropout		34.90%	65.10%

The current study further revealed that dropouts were more obvious among students who were from big families, especially when they were the 4th children or younger members in the family. The dropout history in the family also mattered. The study showed that most dropouts had siblings quitting schools early (before completing basic education---9th grade). Overall, this finding

supported the evidence that family size and sibling order combined with dropout history in the family could be a contributing factor of school student dropouts.

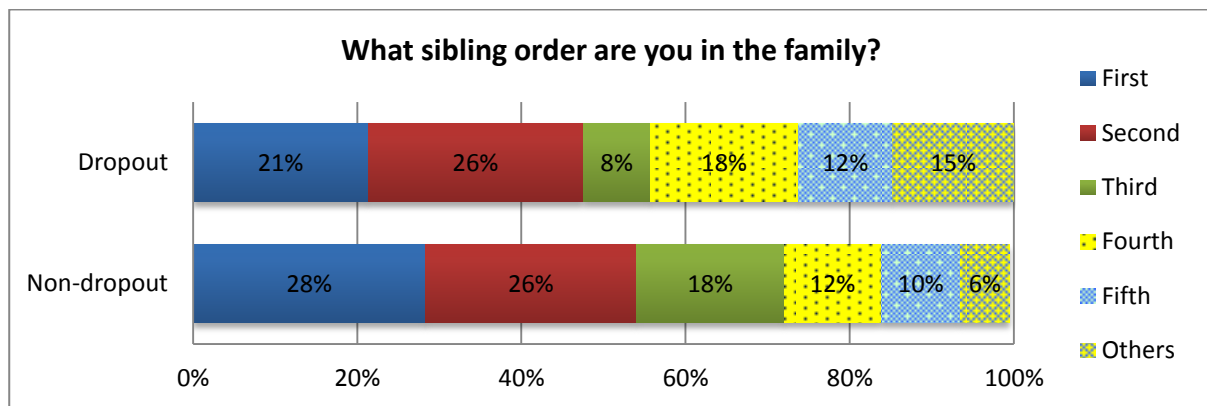


Figure 8: Sibling order of dropout and non-dropout students

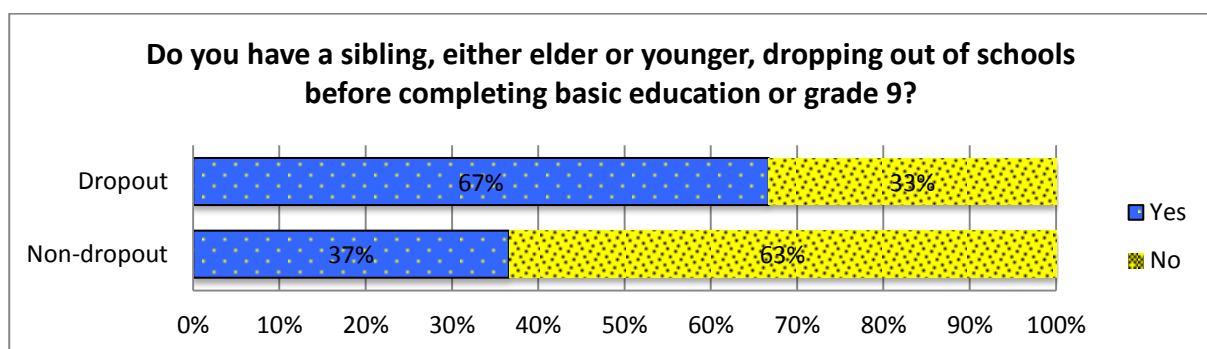


Figure 9: Family history of dropping out of school before grade 9

Helping parents at home and family violence were also found relevant to their decision to depart from school. However, the analysis showed that their impact could be minimal given that the proportional difference was not substantial. Other factors could thus explain better the different characteristics between dropouts and non-dropouts in this study.

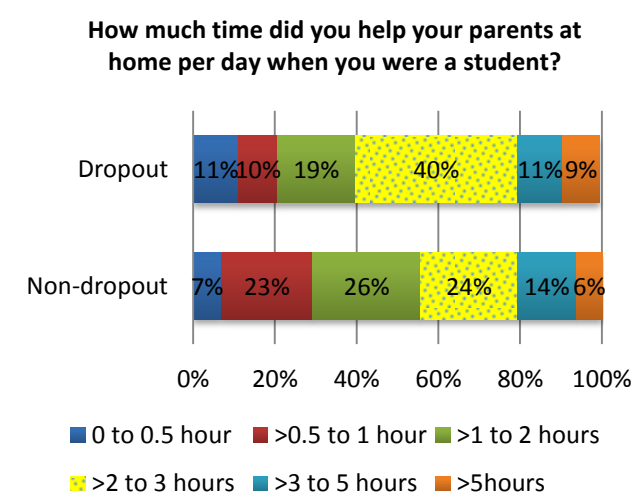


Figure 10: Time spent helping their parents at home

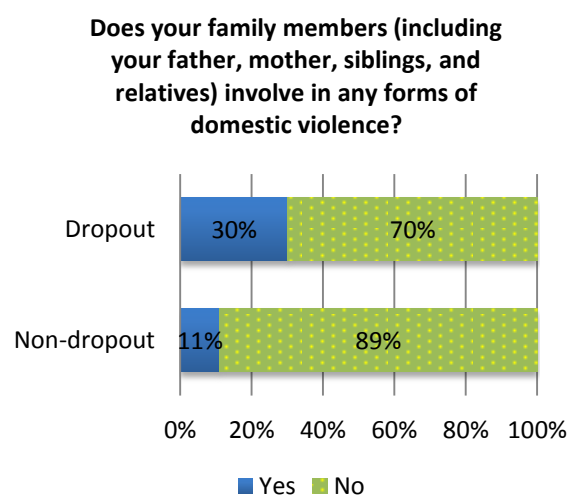


Figure 11: Exposure to domestic violence

5.1.1.4. School factors

School factors were also included in the analysis. But, results showed only two factors that were related to student departure from school. First, dropout students appeared to have more learning difficulty in class. Data showed that they had significantly lower academic achievement compared to their non-dropout counterpart ($p < .05$). Low academic achievement appears to be an early warning sign, reflecting students' likelihood to depart from school.

The lack of emotional attachment to school was also considered a contributing factor linking to school dropout. This study revealed that dropout students felt more emotionally detached from school, particularly from teachers. The analysis showed that they had less close relationship with teachers than their non-dropout peers. This finding appears to indicate that dropout students were less academically integrated into learning and the learning environment.

Many factors would lead to this lack of emotional attachment to school. But a cross-examination of the data showed that an inactive school-home relation could be a critical factor. Reportedly, schools did not play a significant role in motivating students to learn and in retaining them in school. As nearly 70 percent of parents of dropout students reported, schools did not often keep them informed of their children's learning (see Table 5). About sixty percent of parents also mentioned that school did not put any effort in discussing with them as to how to send their children back to school after dropping out. Teachers might have visited students' home once to know whether students quit school or not. After that, no follow-ups or actions were undertaken.

Table 5: School-home relation as perceived by parents of dropout students

Questions asked to parents	Percentage	
	Yes	No
School keeps you informed of your child study.	35%	65%
School puts any effort in convincing you to send your child to go back to school after your child dropout.	40.7%	59.3%

5.1.1.5. Community factors

Students, family and school factors affect students' motivation and commitment to schooling and learning in different manners. Nonetheless, socio-cultural contexts also play a key role in determining children's education in the family and in the community. Our study found that there were obvious disadvantaged contexts where dropout students are living. Demographically, dropout students lived in the community where few adults could complete basic education (grade 9) and where the community appeared to pay less attention to the student learning.

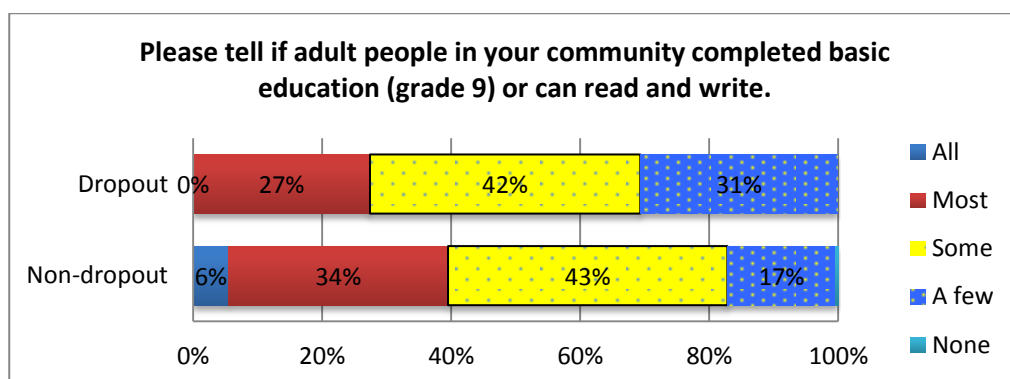


Figure 12: Dropout and non-dropout students' living community

The data showed that there were significantly lower enrollment campaign in the dropout students' community and lower monitoring of student learning. There was also a likely lack of dropout preventions in the community where dropout students were living. In addition, there was a prevalent use of drug (marijuana) in their community. All of these socio-cultural contexts appear to highlight the indifference to the value of education perceived by parents and children themselves, especially by the community at large.

Table 6: Community involvement in schooling

	<i>Types of students</i>	<i>Very Strongly</i>	<i>Strongly</i>	<i>Moderately</i>	<i>Slightly</i>	<i>Not at all</i>
<i>To what extent, do people in your community evolve in school enrollment?</i>	Non-dropout	23.30%	33.50%	37.70%	5.50%	0.00%
	Dropout	3.20%	52.40%	22.20%	7.90%	14.30%
<i>To what extent, do people in your community monitor school teaching and learning process?</i>	Non-dropout	5.00%	7.10%	32.40%	40.80%	14.70%
	Dropout	0.00%	4.80%	20.60%	33.30%	41.30%
<i>To what extent, do people in your community partake in school measures of preventing dropouts?</i>	Non-dropout	1.70%	8.00%	36.10%	36.10%	18.10%
	Dropout	0.00%	11.10%	17.50%	25.40%	46.00%

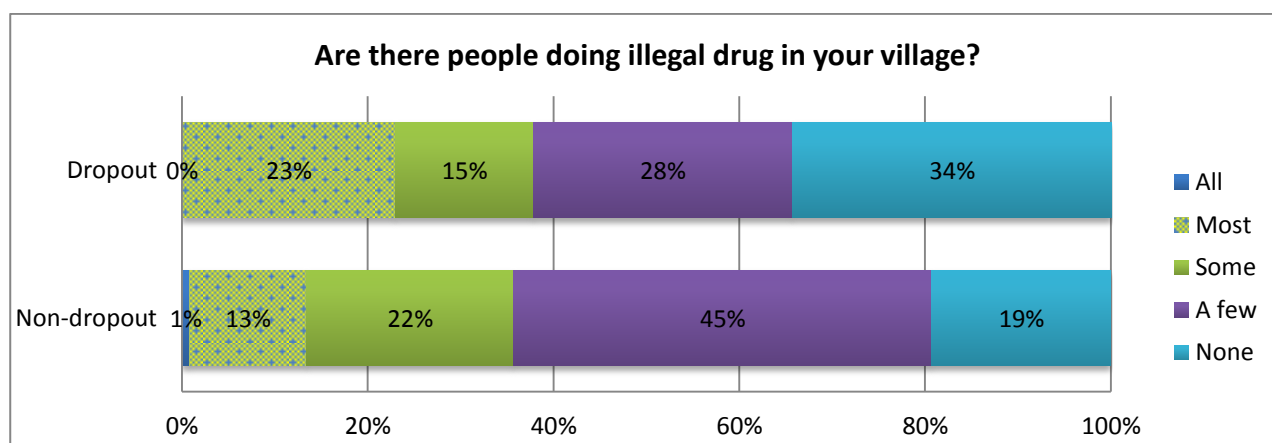


Figure 13: Drug use in the community

5.1.1.6. Scholarship/support

For scholarship and other financial support, this questionnaire survey could not find a clear-cut picture of differentials between dropout and non-dropout students. Data showed that school dropout was not associated with the availability of scholarship or support from the government ($p > .05$).

The lack of significant association is discernable given that only a small number of students got the scholarship from the government, NGOs or development partners (DPs); worse, the amount contained in the scholarship was considerably low (see Table 7). The minimal amount of scholarship received (approximately 50\$ per year) could hardly reduce the financial burden of the children's families, especially within the rural community. The minimal financial support/scholarship was anecdotally insufficient and less attractive if compared to income they would earn from work in the restaurants or other businesses.

Table 7: Scholarship from the government, NGOs or DPs

	<i>Percentage</i>	
<i>Get scholarship from the government, NGOs or DPs</i>	Yes	26.7
	No	73.3
<i>Scholarship and support was enough</i>	Yes	28.6
	No	71.4

5.1.2. Perception of parents of dropouts towards school dropout issues

This part briefly illustrates results distilled from dropout students' parents' responses to the survey questionnaire specifically designed to tap their perspectives towards school dropout and their own conditions/constraints. From the parents' view, although they somehow agreed on other factors contributing to school dropout, poverty was the main impediment to their effort in sending their children to school. The majority of the parents in this study recognized their family was poor, so they could not afford their children's further education. Because their family was poor, they needed the children to help them with the family work or to the job to generate more income (see Table below for detail).

Table 8: Perception of parents of dropout students towards causes of school dropout

<i>Statements</i>	<i>Strongly disagree</i>	<i>Disagree</i>	<i>Neutral</i>	<i>Agree</i>	<i>Strongly agree</i>
1 My child was old for his schooling.	50	38.3	3.3	6.7	1.7
2 My child had health problems.	46.6	31.7	1.7	15	5
3 My child performs poorly in his/her study (normally s/he received very low ranks in class).	15	40	13.3	16.7	15
4 My child repeated the grades many times.	45.8	35.6	6.8	6.8	5
5 I am afraid my child might socialize with bad friends.	35	21.7	3.3	33.3	6.7
6 My family was/is poor we cannot afford their further	16.7	11.7	1.6	40	30

	education.					
7	My family was/is poor so we need(ed) him/her to help with the family work.	15	16.7	3.3	31.7	33.3
8	My family had financial problems (receiving loan from the bank or others) and we need him or her to do job to help generate more incomes.	23.4	23.3	3.3	23.3	26.7
9	I felt that more education would not make much difference in their lives.	23.3	43.3	6.7	10	16.7
10	Everyone in the village did not need much education to be rich or live happily.	15.2	49.2	16.9	11.9	6.8
11	I do not think education system in Cambodia is good quality.	20.7	31	31	7	10.3
12	My child needed to get married.	64.4	33.9	0	1.7	0
13	My child needed to take care of other family members who are ill, aged or younger.	45.8	32.1	1.7	13.6	6.8
14	My child wanted to quit as he/she felt isolated at school.	43.1	29.3	12.1	13.8	1.7
15	My child was afraid to go to school as teachers forced them to pay informal school fees.	42.4	32.1	6.8	10.2	8.5
16	The teachers were absent, so my kids did not learn much from going to school.	46.7	33.3	10	10	0
17	Teachers did not teach my child well even though they came to school. They just taught to fulfill their duties.	44	35.6	13.6	3.4	3.4
18	Teachers or principal normally used violence at school.	54.2	35.6	3.4	5.1	1.7
19	I did not like the teacher and the school principal.	51.7	38.3	8.3	1.7	0
20	My kid was afraid to go to school as there was bullying in school by other students.	48.3	36.7	6.7	5	3.3
21	The school was far from home.	43.3	35	3.4	18.3	0
22	I felt it was not safe to let my kid go to school as there were risks of crimes.	35	43.3	5	13.3	3.4

5.2. The qualitative findings

This section presents a qualitative analysis of the eight schools. Qualitative analysis is important to understand the context, the people, and the interaction. The design for this section is that of a case study. The data for this section comprises of visual data, field notes, observation, and interviews with focuses given to participants' experience, opinions, and feelings. The report was written using both descriptive and narrative approaches loosely divided into themes and characteristics.

Table 9: Summary of studied secondary school profiles

School	# Principal	# Deputy	Appr. Dis. From PP	Teacher		Teachers Total	Students		Stud. Total
				M	F		M	F	
Chambok Meas	1	1 (1F)	20 kms, NR6	15	9	24	123	79	202
Chamroeun Cheat	1	2 (2M)	9 kms, NR5	15	11	26	141	158	299
Prek Reang	1	0	25 kms, NR5/6	11	5	16	65	86	151
Kong Noy	1	0	20 kms NR2/3	11	9	20	24	18	42

Chhay Chhop	1	2 (1M, 1F)	50 kms, NR4	28	26	54	291	297	588
Boeng Khna	1	0	40 kms, NR4	4	4	8	91	90	181
Chha-en	1	0	105 kms NR44	6	2	8	40	56	96
Teap Mean	1	0	65 kms, NR44	7	4	11	58	53	111

1. Chambok Meas

Chambok Meas was the first school our research team visited. It is located along national road number six, only about twenty kilometers away from Phnom Penh. The school was an easy find locating right along the national road in the compound of an old pagoda. The pagoda had been moved to the new location on the other side of the road, leaving the old compound for both primary and secondary schools of Chambok Meas.

When we arrived, we found the gate locked. One of our team members had to walk a short distance to the office, a typical classroom converted into an office, and asked for the gate to be unlocked. A gentleman ran to unlock the door for us. In front of the office, we found several teachers, male and female, gathering around and chitchatted away. As we approached, the deputy principal came to greet us. We introduced ourselves and soon realized we were expected and thirty students from grades 7 and 8 were ready for us to be interviewed. Unfortunately, the principal was in a meeting in Phnom Penh and would not return to assist us until in the afternoon.

We divided our team members into three groups and each group was interviewing ten students. The team members read the questionnaire to the students and explained all the answers to them before giving the students some time to choose their answers. After making sure the answer one question is properly answered, the process continued.

After we finished with the non-dropouts, we asked for the help from the deputy principal to help us locate houses of the dropouts identified in a list handed down by the principal. It was nearly the lunch break. The deputy principal, with help from a male teacher, took us to find the first dropout, a young girl in her mid teen. We found the house empty and thus proceeded to the next.

This time we found the grandmother of the second dropout and was told the girl had moved to Phnom Penh to work in a factory with her mother. She would only come home on the weekend with her mother. "Her father didn't want her to stop," said the grandmother. "He would even beat her at first for refusing to go to school. So she decided to live with her mother in Phnom Penh instead," the grandmother added.



Figure 14: The house of the first drop-out interviewed at Chambok Meas looking from the drop-out grandmother's house. (Credit Sok Soth)

In their wooden house built about a meter and a half above the ground with old rusty zinc wall and clay roof, lived only the father and a younger sister, also a drop-out. The house was built behind the mother-in-law of the man, about ten meter away toward the rear end of the fence. From the grandmother, we learned that the father worked as a brick factory worker. We were told he would normally come home for lunch and as it was almost lunch time for him, we waited. Soon, the father arrived on an old bike. He was wearing a torn green hat that looked browned with dirt and grime. As he saw us, he smiled taking his hat off in a gesture of politeness. We introduced ourselves and our purpose before asking him for permission for the interview. We decided we would interview his daughter in Phnom Penh later instead. We got her number and the permission to do the interview from the father.

When we were finished with the first family, we came back to the first house by which we stopped. At the wooden house built directly on the ground, we found the father and the daughter who dropped out. Several dogs barked fiercely as we entered the house and introduced ourselves. Having found permissions, we interviewed the father and the daughter. We learned he was a university dropout. He had been studying sculpture in the Royal University of Fine Art for three years before he decided to dropout for financial reasons. He said he did not want his daughter to quit school, but admitted that she was of great help to him as a single father whose wife had run away. Since it was also her wish to quit school to help at home, he inevitably agreed to her wish. Having finished with the second family, we decided to have lunch before meeting the principal at around half past one to find other dropouts' families.

The Nature of Dropout in Chambok Meas

Having finished collecting all the information from the needed number of dropouts in Chambok Meas, it was clearly noticeable that many of the dropouts' parents did very little when their children complained that they could not make sense of the lessons at school any more and thus wished to quit school. The parents should have done more to find out the real causes of their children's "not being able to make sense at school". Although all of the parents agreed that education was important, as specified in the questionnaire, it was what their children could do to help with the families' living conditions that outweighed the importance of staying in school, be it staying at home and helping with the household chores or generating extra incomes for the family.

What was even more interesting was that among all the dropouts in Chambok Meas that we interviewed, very few were actually apparently too poor to afford keeping their children in school. Although this view is purely based on the observable assets of the families, many of which owned their own land and well-built houses of reasonably sizes and quality, it is arguable that had the parents had the intention to see their children finish secondary school, if not high school, many of the dropouts should have stayed in school.

The school should also have done more to deal with the issues of dropout more seriously. It was observable that the teachers and the principal hardly knew anything significant about the dropouts. Most of the times, the teachers and the students depended on the dropouts' peers to identify who dropped out, when, and why they did as well as what happened to them at the time. Had the teachers and the school reached out to these drop-outs to understand why they decided to quit school as well as to highlight to them and their parents why they should have stayed in school, the dropout rate would have been different; the parents could have done more to convince their children to stay in school.

2. Chamroeun Cheat

Chamroeun Cheat was about nine kilometers away from Phnom Penh along national road number five. The school was hidden behind rows of houses with a small pathway leading to the school whose side and front gates had to be opened at all time or the connection between a small village road would be disrupted from the pathway that linked it to the main road. This posed serious issues with trespassing and vandalism. As a result, the respectable statue of the King Jayavaraman VII was deliberately vandalized in various forms. Other reasons were also unearthed related to the vandalism of the statue.



Figure 15: A narrow pathway linking the front gate of Chamroeun Cheat to National Road 5 (Credit Sok Soth)



Figure 16: The statue of the respectable King Jayavarman VII was vandalized in various ways (Credit Sok Soth)

When we arrived, we were greeted by the two deputy principals of the school. We introduced ourselves and the purpose for visiting and were told the principal would be coming soon. We were invited to wait in the meeting room in the office, which was a classroom on the ground floor modified to be an office and a meeting room. The office looked busy and each desk was full with documents and work waiting to be finished. On the wall, several wall fans were waiting to be turned on. Outside the office, the summer heat was gathering its intensity.

On the main wall of the office, four big white boards were displaying in permanent ink different staff duties and statistics of staff, teachers and students starting from the academic years 2007-2008 onwards. Over the years, the supplies of grade 7 students decreased steadily. In the school years of 2007-2008, 424 students were enrolled in the seventh grade of the school, among whom 212 were female. Two years later there were only 178 (94 female) enrolling. The statistics bounded back in the years 2012-2013 during which 366 (172 female) were enrolled. Then the number progressively decreased again. In the years 2015-2016, only 151 (82 female) were enrolled in the seventh grade.

When the principal finally came, the meeting started. We soon learned that about 90% of the students were Muslim and none of the 26 teachers was Muslim. The students were allowed to pray in the nearby mosques during their pray times. It did not take long to learn that there was an absence of unity and mutual understanding between the school and the community. “When the students need to be absent and they are not allowed for certain reasons, they would approach the school support committee for intervention,” said the principal. According to the official website of the Temple Garden Foundation (TGF),

The School Support Committee (SSC) is an important group which helps ensure that education and school development goals are met. All schools are required to establish a SSC. This is done by recruiting at least seven people who represent the villagers in any decision making for the school's development (2014)⁵.

⁵ <http://www.tgfcambodia.com/news/school-support-committee-training>

The school management also complained about how the houses owners in the front part of the school would let their bathroom waste water flow across the street into the school compound creating a small lagoon of sewage water. "We decided to build the wall up, and now the waste water flows along the street," a deputy principal said.

After the meeting, the principal left. He assigned one of his deputies to assist us in the data collection with the drop-outs. Some of our team started our routines with the non-dropouts while the rest started looking for the drop-outs and their families to be interviewed.

The Nature of Dropout in Chamreoun Cheat

When asked about the primary reasons for dropouts during the meeting with the school management, we were told that lack of priority over state school education, family mobility, and poverty were three main causes for student dropouts.

Lack of priority over state school education referred to the students' and their families' choices of giving up state education for a religious one at a certain level when basic literacy in Khmer was met or when the religious studies at their local mosques were offered with some benefits from various religious organizations. Neither of the deputy principals could clearly identify any religious organizations that were offering such education. However, they were aware that besides studying religious contents, numeracy was also taught.

Family mobility was a reason for dropout as many of the dropouts had to move with their families who earned livings from selling potteries and other similar products in selling trips to various provinces all over the countries. Some families would leave their children under the cares of elderly or distant relatives so that they could continue their schooling. However, most of these students usually dropped out after a certain period of time. Lacking proper care and family supports for both physical and psychological needs could be the reasons that distract them from studying.

Finally, poverty was also a cause of dropout for many of the students interviewed. An interesting case related to this factor emerged as our research team was interviewing a young girl in her late 15 who did not wish to stop schooling but was suggested so by her elder sister who got a job in a factory. During the interview, she was asked, "Under what circumstances would you go back to school?" The girl looked reluctant to answer and kept glancing at her mother who was busy tidying the house nearby. When encouraged to answer, she said she did not really want to stop, but her family was poor and since her sister now had a job, she was needed at home to help look after her sickly mother. She could also help generate a little extra income from selling porridge in front of her home in a makeshift table under a tree. A big piece of thick cloth was tied up at all four ends serving as the roof. Many young children were gathering around listening to our interview. "I miss school," she said looking down at the ground, her voice was like a whisper. "I miss my friends," she added. This time tears were welling her eyes.



Figure 17: The house and the makeshift shop of the young girl who was forced to drop out due to family's poverty. (Credit Sok Soth)

Through the interviews with the dropouts' families, it was confirmed that poverty was a reason. We were unable to confirm if family mobility was another reason because none of the dropouts due to this reason was available in the community for the interviews. In addition, many families did emphasize on their preference for their children to be educated in the mosques by those religious groups. When asked if the children received any financial support from studying there, none confirmed this to be the case. They smiled when answering though.

An interesting reason that we unearthed during our interviews with the parents was that some teachers at school used various means to gain financial benefits from the students—selling handouts, private tutoring, and “insincere saving”. “My son kept asking me for 500 riels every day to give to the teacher,” said a mother whose son study at the school. She looked in her early 40s. “He told me they were playing a saving game. At the end of the school year, the teacher will return all the saved money back to everyone,” she continued. “I doubt it,” she added with a serious tone.

3. Prek Reang

Prek Reang was located approximately 25 kilometers away from Phnom Penh. The school could be accessible through either national road number five or national road number six. A small but very busy road connected the school with the national road. It took around 30 minutes just to travel this short distance as it was not only bumpy but also very dusty. The school looked isolated with a few houses in sight. Upon arrival, our team was warmly greeted by the school principal and their staffs. There were not many trees in the school compound, but the school itself appeared to be in good condition for learning and teaching.

Prek Reang was the only school among the eight that had a Facebook page. On its official Facebook page, visitors will be greeted by a message from the school principal. The message read:

Greeting to all respectable brothers and sisters. My name is Nhem Pouy, the principal of the Prek Reang Secondary School, Khan Chroy Chongvar, Phnom Penh. The school has been declared by the ministry of education as a school located in area facing difficulties in Phnom Penh. In these 2015-2106 academic years, the total number of the students in the school is 151, 86 of whom are female. The school has 16 employees, 5 of whom are female.

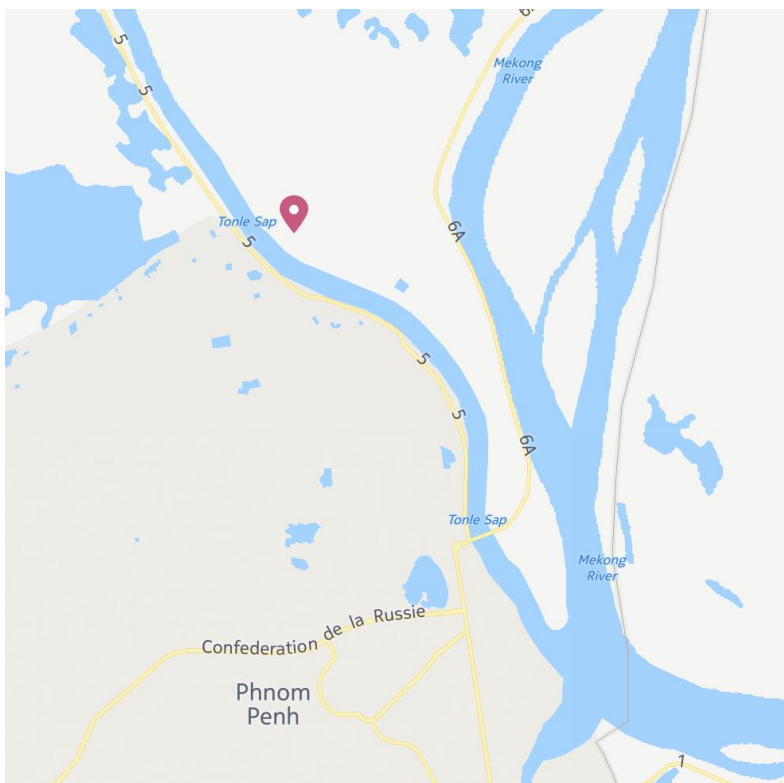


Figure 18: The location of Prek Reang Secondary School (Credit: Google Map)



Figure 19: First day of the 2015-2016 academic year of Prek Reang Secondary School. (Credit: School Facebook)

After a quick meeting, two of our team started the data collection procedure among the non-dropouts. At the same time, one of our team members started interviewing the school principal about the staffs, student and some of the school development issues. There was also a parent and a dropout who came to school after they principal invited them. They were interviewed by yet another team. After we finished, we continued our quest for more dropouts and parents at the nearby villages with the assistant from the school principal and a few students.

The Nature of Dropout in Prek Reang

The principal shared with our team some primary reasons for dropout. The first and most common reason was that those dropouts needed to help their families to generate more income. There were many things they could do—working in factories, growing and selling vegetables. An almost similarly prominent reason was the insecurity of commuting from houses to school and vice versa. Some parts of the road were so quiet and there were cases of rapes and robberies. A quick Google search of the village name resulted in news story of drug uses and murders.



Figure 20: A screen capture of a news story about drug users being caught on their way back from buying drug. Both drug users lived in Prek Reang Village.
(Source: <https://kohsantepheapdaily.com.kh/article/92839.html> Retrieved May 29, 2016)

Road safety was another issue. The small dirt road was busy with dump trucks carrying dirt driving a full speed back and forth. They posted serious dangers to young students riding their bikes to and back from school.

Finally, many students quit school because the school was an incomplete secondary school. A student put it best, “Students who finish this school have to go a high school which is quite far from here. The problems we face are worsened and we don’t want to risk any further. Quitting will happen. It is just a matter of time. Many quit now, not waiting till having to go to high school.”

Nevertheless, poverty was not always the prime reason. Another dropout tearfully told us that, “My family was not poor at all compared to other families who were our neighbors, but my parents put pressure on me to quit school in order to help them with their business of growing and selling vegetables. I did want to study and complete grade 12. I did have a dream to become a beautician.” She also requested our team not to visit her house as she felt ashamed and was afraid that our visit could trigger a quarrel in her family. She must have had enough of it. We agreed to her request. We did not want to cause any further stress on her. We left with heavy hearts.

4. Kong Noy

Kong Noy was about 20 kilometers away from Phnom Penh along national road number two. Although travelling along the nation road number two was closer to the school, our team took the national road number three as we needed to pick up one of our members along the way. It was roughly a 50 minutes ride. We got to the school at around 9.00 AM. The school principal and a few teachers were anxiously waiting for the arrival of our team. We found that the environment of school was neither neat nor green. One building served both learning and working functions.

As usual, we started our fieldwork—one member interviewed the school principal, the other two assisted 30 students completing the questionnaire in two separate rooms and one conducted interviews with dropouts and their parents.

We soon learned from the students that their teachers, mostly young, were very committed to help them learn. The students overtly expressed their love and gratitude toward their teachers' commitment of regularly travelling a long distance to deliver their teaching service at this poor school. Those whose houses were between 20 and 30 kilometers away were arranged to come to teach two or three days in a row and they can rest on the other days. One of our team members also had an informal talk with those teachers and confirmed what the students had said. The recent increase in their salaries had a big impact on their motivations.

After we finished our job at the school, the principals and a few students accompanied our team to locate houses of dropouts and their parents. Our jobs were a lot easier that day as these students' houses were not far away from the school.

The Nature of Dropout in Kong Noy

Several main causes of dropout were found in Kong Noy. First of all, low academic performance was frequently referred to by dropouts and their parents as the major reason for dropout. "I did not learn very well," a dropout said. "I could not read and remember what teacher covered in the class. I frustrated me. I was demotivated to go to school any more."

Second, children's roles at home was another reason. Based on dropouts' and their parents' perceptions, helping the family with farming, cooking, cleaning and taking care of their family members also made some students miss classes very often. After a long while, they began to lose concentration on their study and finally decided to leave school for good. Some current job opportunities as factory workers for female students and construction workers for male students also outweighed the importance of education at school.

Third, attending incomplete secondary school could lead to some students dropping out as well. Similar to the other schools visited, Kong Noy had only grades 7 8 and 9. This made some of dropouts and their parents come up with an excuse that even dropouts stayed at schools they would end up just passing grade 9 and could not continue their study to the next level. Surprisingly, our team learned that the next level school stood just about 3 or 4 kilometer from this school.

Fourth, a few dropout parents complained that even they sent their children to school, their children would not learn much as their teachers did not come to teach very often. Those who did come would normally teach just so they fulfilled their jobs. This was completely different from the

accounts we had gathered from the non-dropouts and their teachers. This could be the excuse parents used to justify their decisions not to continue their children's education.

Finally, a sudden increase of land price in the area also greatly influenced some parents' value on education. Most of the families residing there paid great attention on selling their land and gave no interest in investing in their children learning. A parent who used to work as a teacher summarized the whole situation of dropping out in Kong Noy best: "My family had been cheated by my close friends and we lost 100,000 dollars. Now we were deeply in debt so we needed all our children to help us earn money by doing our business and farming. We have been trying to sell our available land, too." She had five children and four of them did not finish grade nine.

5. Chhay Chhop

We arrived at Chhay Chhop and found the school very quiet. In the office, several teachers were chatting on their motorbikes. To the right hand side under the shades of several trees, a group of students were chatting while the others playing. Khmer New Year was three days away, but the students had stopped coming to school. After a brief meeting with the teachers and the principal, two of our team members started our data collection with the non-dropouts who had been arranged to come to school on the day for the purpose. The other two members of the team went into the villages around the school looking for the dropouts and their family.

It turned out to be the most difficult data collection from the dropouts so far. For one, the villages wherein the dropouts lived were connected by dirt roads with potholes of various size. The van that carried us usually ran at around 10 kms/h on average. The roads were also very quiet. If a student had to ride his/her bike home early before class ended for any specific reason, he/she must have been scared. It would be unlikely for anyone to hear a scream for help along those roads.

However, when we arrived in the villages, we were surprised by the tall big houses that greeted our eyes along both sides of the roads. Many of them looked relatively new and were of similar design, about two to three meters tall with an open space on the ground floor but wooden walls on the first, connected by two flights of stairs. The roads in the village were also very well-paved although they were similarly quiet. The cause for this quietness was another reason that made the data collection from the drop-out in those village very difficult. Those who quitted school had all gone to work in the factories. Those who were under age were able to do so with some faking of the needed documents. In some families, all workable ages were working in the factories. In others, daughters and mothers would work in those factories, while their fathers would be motor-taxi drivers instead. With everyone in the family helped earn a living, the living conditions of many families were transforming very quickly. Locating both parents and dropouts for interviewing was extremely hard in such a situation. We were lucky when we discovered a local drinking water factory with many of our target dropouts working there.



Figure 21: The relatively new but quiet houses in one of the villages around Chhay Chhop secondary school. (Credit Sok Soth)

The Nature of Dropout in Chhay Chhop

Major reasons for quitting school in Chhay Chhop were being left out by peers, job opportunities, immediate needs to help improve families' living conditions, materialism, and lack of support to see the importance of further education.

Being left out to be the only one or two in the village coming to and going back from school everyday was a concern for many students who dropped out. "I usually come to school together with other girls in my village," a 16 years old dropout told us. She had been waiting for her paper work to apply to work in a factory. She looked much smaller and younger than her age. "But when most of them quit school to work in factories, I was afraid going to and coming from school with just a friend," she added. When asked if anything bad had ever happened to students on their way to and back from school, she shook her head. "Not that I know of," she said. "But it's better be safe than sorry."

Job opportunities were another reason that tempted those students to drop out. Those who were fit or at suitable ages could easily get jobs in factories either in Kampong Speu Town or around the suburb of Phnom Penh. Those who were too young and unfit found work at the suburb of the provincial town. "My daughter is not home," said the mother of a dropout. She was looking after a baby. An elderly lady was sitting next to her. "She is helping a relative selling goods in the town," the mother added. We also interviewed three individuals in a small drinking water factory near the town.



Figure 22: A young dropout working with his friends in a small drinking water factory near Kampong Speu town. (Credit Sok Soth)

Another reason that attracted students to quit school in Chhay Chhop was the short term needs to help generate extra incomes for the families. This situation was common among the less-than-average families. In these families, parents appeared to do very little to encouraged their children to stay in school longer. Some even suggested the idea to their children. Together with the plentiful jobs available, many found it hard to stay in school.

Nevertheless, the average and the more-than-average families also saw the needs to pull their children out of school to make extra money for a big house, TV, motorbike, cellular phone, plowing hand tractor and the like. “My daughter gave me some of her salary,” said a mother. “She saves the rest for her new clothes and jewelry.”

Finally, it was the lack of support for the likely-to-drop-out to see long-term importance of education that made many students quit school. The school had no activities to highlight this feature, and neither did the commune or village chiefs. More importantly, there was also hardly any role models for them to see how transforming education can be for a person. When asked how many people in their village earned a descent living from high education, no dropout could single out such individuals.

6. Boeng Khna

Boeng Khna was nearer to Phnom Penh than Chhay Chhop. Along National Road number 4, we turned left after Prey Pdao market along a small but well-paved road. About five kilometers later, we turned right and travelled about two or three kilometers until we saw a pagoda gate. We turned left and entered the gate. The road passed through many villages, all quite big in size. Along a dirt road, about five or six kilometers later we saw a pagoda. Boeng Khna secondary school was right next to the pagoda.

When we arrived the principal and some parents along with their children were waiting for us. The principal had arranged 30 non-dropouts and several dropouts for the interviews. This made the data collection job much easier and faster than usual. We only had to go down to a nearby village to find three more dropouts to finish our information collection for the school. So far, it was the fastest.

The Nature of Dropout in Boeng Khna

Being in a similar location to Chhay Chhop, surrounded by factories and job opportunities, the nature of dropout in Boeng Khna was similar in all aspects to those of Chhay Chhop.



Figure 23: The research team of Faculty of Education, RUPP, took a picture with a KOICA team under the house of a dropout in Boeng Khna, Kampong Speu. (Credit Sok Soth)

7. Chha-en

Among all the schools, Chha-en was the most remote. It took us nearly three hours to get there. We left Phnom Penh around five o'clock in the morning and arrived in Kampong Speu at around half past six. We had a quick breakfast and continued our journey to Chbar Morn town before turning off to National Road 44. We drove all the way to Oralh district along a very good road with very little traffic. We arrived at Oralh at around twenty past seven. We had about twenty kilometers left to reach Chha-en.

The remaining twenty kilometers took us nearly an hour to drive. It was a dirt road with big potholes and uneven surfaces. Sometimes we had to drive into small streams that dried up during the dry season. The surface of the road was covered with fine powdery dust at ankle deep and of milky color. Hundreds of handheld plowing machines converted into log carrying vehicles were travelling back and forth along the road churning up the dust to make the sky look foggy. Those who went from the direction of Oralh were empty while those who came back to Oralh were heavy loaded with logs of different sizes. Along the road from Oralh, there was no signs of language being used in any ways—no road signs, no posters raising people awareness of cleanliness and health issues like elsewhere. There were only small houses sparsely scattering along the road. The forest along the road looked thin with big tall trees removed. Those young tree looked leafless covering with thick dust.



Figure 24: Road conditions from Oralh to Chha-en secondary school. (Credit Sok Soth)

We arrived at Chha-en at twenty past eight in the morning. The school had two buildings, one very old and the other quite new. The old building was made from wood with zinc roof. Each room was empty and unused. The classes had been moved to the new building located side by side with the old one. The new building was built from bricks and cement with red zinc roof. It has four classrooms, one of which was turned into the school office. The school also had a teacher dorm recently built for teachers whose houses were far from school. The dorm could accommodate four teachers. It had two rooms and a toilet.

Greeting us was the principal, a young man in his thirties, tall, fit, and well-built. The principal was friendly and active. He cordially introduced us into the office and we told him our purpose of being there. We learned then that the communities around the school comprised of Suoy tribe mostly. We also learned that the students' parents could still communicate in their tribal language but that their children were all fluent in Khmer being influenced by TV and radio program as well as open access for trades and other interactions with the Khmer community.

Since the principal had already prepared the non-dropouts for us, two of our team started the data collection from them straight away while the rest interviewed two of the dropouts who were invited to the school. We then went with the students to interview their parents as well as locating the other dropouts.

The Nature of Dropout in Chha-en

The most common reason for dropout in Chha-en was poverty. The school was located in a remote area. Children were expected to help their families in any ways they could. While girls could help with household chores, boys were needed to help their family by going to the forest to cut woods for both firewood and logging. At secondary level, the children were at the ages of being most useful for such helps in their families.

Together with the fact that most of the parents received very little education themselves and that there were hardly any job opportunities in or around the villages that required, it was hard to give the students and their parent's motivation to stay in school. Our team also found out that there had been only two students in the villages who had finished grade 12. Even so, these students did not wish to become teachers and could not use the knowledge to do anything significant in their communities. In short, finishing high school or not, the students were likely to end up doing what their families had been traditionally doing, i.e., farming, logging, hunting, to name a few.

In addition, there was also little instances of literacy being used to inspire the students to stay in school. Although there were exposures through TV, few houses could afford a television. The most common way for the people, young and old, to entertain themselves was through playing VCDs of Thai dramas dubbed into Khmer using small cheap laptops, around ten inches in screen size. Several of the dropouts were found watching such VCDs during the lunchtime of the day.



Figure 25: A dropout from Chha-en led us to her house to meet her parents for the interview. (Credit Sok Soth)

8. Teap Mean

Teap Mean, although not as remote as Chha-en, it was still quite a secluded place. To get to the school, we had to turn right after travelling the national road 44 for 13 kilometers. The small dirt road marked with a pagoda gate at the entrance extended for five or six kilometers to the villages whose students came to Teap Mean primary and secondary schools. Young forests were growing along both sides of the road creating eerie feelings insecure when using the road. The school was the first building at which we arrived before the villages.



Figure 26: The dirt road to Teap Mean Secondary school. (Credit Sok Soth)

The school had two buildings, one for primary school and the other for secondary school. When entering the compound, the first building to the left was the primary school. Further away to the left was a newer building. That was Teap Mean secondary school. Both buildings were built from

bricks and cement with red clay roof tiles. Several trees were found in front of each building giving shades for the students to relax and play. Both buildings were beautifully decorated with slogans that encouraged the students to study hard and to be environmentally friendly.

After arriving, we had a brief meeting before proceeding to collecting data from the non-dropouts. As usual, the remaining team member had to go down to the villages to interview the dropouts. The principal was the one leading us to find these students and their parents. It turned out to be a data collection unlike anything we have done so far.

The Nature of Dropout in Teap Mean

Among all the target dropouts in Teap Mean, only two were available for us to interview on the day. The rest had to be interviewed by phone later in the evening when our team already returned to Phnom Penh. We could only interview their parents in the village. We sought their permission to call their children between 5-7 pm on the day after they all returned home. This was the case because the students who had dropped out were all working in factories in Kampong Speu.

When we asked the parents if education was important for their children, all dropouts' parents readily admitted that it was important. However, when asked if they had done enough to persuade their children to go back to school, many were finding excuses for failing to do so. The excuses included, "We chased him back to school too, but he didn't listen...", "She said she was embarrassed to go back...", "She said she couldn't make sense of the lessons any more...", "He said he can't concentrate on studying seeing how poor we are..."

One mother though sincerely expressed her sadness that her daughter, a very talented artist, had to quit school because she had asked her to do so at first. "Last year we married our first son," said the mother. She looked in her early forties and slightly overweight. "This year we married our daughter, the second child. Two marriages left us with some debts. I decided to get a job in the factory and later my third child, the one who dropped out, also joined me. She said she wanted to help pay out the debts sooner. I tried to stop her but she said she had made up her mind already. Three months later my first two children who were married were able to help us pay the debt, so I asked my third child to go back to school. She disagreed. She enjoyed her work and the money she earned. She has her own saving now."

Like in Chhay Chhop, the dropouts were able to generate significant incomes for the family. We observed how new and grand the villagers' houses were. A few were being erected. Apparently, it was the strive to upgrade their socio-economic status that distracted many students from staying at school while luring their parents to persist on their children finishing high schools.

5.3. Comparative case studies

As repeatedly put throughout the report, this study was conducted in Phnom Penh and Kompong Speu as ways to document a comparative picture of school dropout contained in urban and rural locations. This section thus serves that purpose well. Drawn from in-depth analyses in the preceding sections, this study concludes that the nature of school dropout was geographically different to the extent that might be inconceivable without unlocking these comparative case studies. While poverty, job opportunity (generating more family income), and the need for domestic and care work were commonplace in both locations, factors including the lack of

religious schools, family mobility, insecurity surrounding school, incomplete schools, repeated absence, low academic achievement, private fee at school, and debt due to land business compound the impact on city children to quit school or their parents' decision to pull them out of school.

Some appealing factors that might not be the case in the city were, however, manifested in the rural schools. The findings of this study point to a conclusion that in rural areas, peer pressure, lack of value to education among parents, low literacy among parents and youth, little job opportunities, and debt due to repeated marriage of their children all represented as the pullout factors relating to school dropout. Apparently, apart from the vicious poverty constraint, in rural areas community influences affected the values to education greatly, thereby thwarting local people's aspiration to invest in the education of their children, especially girls.

6. Conclusions and recommendations

6.1. Conclusions

The findings of this study draw on both quantitative and qualitative data to examine school dropout issues in selected schools in Phnom Penh city and Kompong Speu. Despite different methodological fronts, the two methods reveal coherent and concrete facts explaining dropout phenomena and contexts. They can be classified into school, family, individual and community factors.

6.1.1. From the quantitative data

Based on the quantitative data, various characteristics were found to be contributing to school dropout. They included a wide range of issues from the low academic achievement to the lack of emotional attachment or a sense of belonging to school, to parents' lower educational background and aspiration, to lack of homeschooling or guidance/support from parents to students, to big family size, to arguably low value to education, to dropout history in the family, to child labor and to domestic violence. Late entry, low self-esteem, lack of preschool experience, low educational aspiration, undesired attitude toward school, absences from school and low commitment to doing homework all one way or another account for varied characteristics of dropout and non-dropouts. The study also found obvious evidence linking to community factors such as youth's low literacy in the community, risks and insecurity due to the use of drug (marijuana), and the lack of student enrollment campaign and dropout prevention within both urban and rural community.

6.1.2. From the qualitative data

The qualitative evidence adds both rigor and richness to our study as similar issues were manifested from the interviews, observations, field notes and visual aids. In terms of school, two other factors could be identified—location and school support. Those schools located near economically thriving town or city saw significant number of dropouts quitting school to help their families earned better living. Whether their family was already in a better off position in terms of assets and materials was not a determining factor to make the students stay in school. As a result, some dropouts were from quite sufficient families compared with many who continued to stay in school. Besides school location, school support, or rather the lack of it, was also a factor that contributing to the dropouts found in this study. School principals and teachers had put little, if at all, effort in finding out the cause that made the students quit school. There was also a lack of

mechanism to attract these students back to school. Many school principals and teachers appeared to feel that their roles were to provide the education and the students roles were to decide whether or not to come or stay in school.

Family factor can also be divided into two smaller streams—the parents' level of education and their socio-economic status. Many of the dropouts were from families whose parents themselves had very little education. Although the parents acknowledged the importance of education, this acknowledgement was not concrete enough to see significant influences on their children's staying in school. Many parents even expected the schools, particularly the teachers, to do more to make their children see the usefulness of staying in school. From the children's perspectives, it was hard for them to remain in school seeing that their parents could nonetheless make a living even with little education. Also concern with the parents, children could as well quit school because they could not tolerate seeing how hard their parents work in order to make a living. For those who were already better, it was the desire to move up the scale of plentiful living and materialism that made them drop out of schools.

Age was yet another factor that contributed to the dropout in this study. When students were young, they were of little help at home. For many, they were even burdens for their parents hindering their full potential of going away from home regularly to earn a living. Sending them to school was therefore a good choice as they could get their children educated while freeing themselves some time to make a living. This changed, however, when these children reached grade secondary school. At around 16 and 18 years of ages, these young students were of great help for the family. They could look after their younger siblings, sick or old family members, or help their families make a living if not other household chores. As a result, those who faced unsupportive conditions in their families had no choices but quit school. This was common in those eight schools examined in this study.

Finally, it was community factors that contributed to the dropout. There was little community support and awareness of the issues of dropout. Village and commune chiefs thought that it was the responsibilities of both the students' families and the schools to make them stay in schools. Students and their families were not made aware of the importance of literacy in their everyday lives. Radios and TV programs did very little to raise this awareness as well. In remote schools, the lack of evidence of how literacy can impact lives for better made students see no reasons for studying. Although there were some scholarships given to underprivileged students, these scholarships were hardly enough. A girl who dropped out from Chamroeun Cheat stated that she could make at least 10000 Riel (2.5US\$) per day if stayed home and helped her parents sell porridges and soft-drinks at homes while her parents were out making more money. This made the government scholarships of around 50\$ per year highly insignificant to motivate them to stay in school.

6.1.3. Comparative case studies

As for school dropout issues in urban and rural areas, this study concluded that poverty, job opportunity (generating more family income), and the need for domestic and care work were commonplace in both locations. However, schooling opportunities of city students appeared to be more constrained by the lack of religious schools, family mobility, insecurity surrounding school, incomplete schools, their repeated absence, low academic achievement, private fee at school, and family debt due to land business.

In the rural case, this research study found that peer pressure, lack of value to education among parents, low literacy among parents and youth, little job opportunities, and debt due to repeated marriage of their children combined with the community people's lessened value to education were more common causes of school dropout.

6.2. Recommendations

Based on the findings of the current study, a number of recommendations are provided to reduce dropout, particularly for at-risk students as the following:

1. School and community support mechanisms to inform students and their families of importance of staying in school.
 - a. Schools should actively identify which students are vulnerable to dropout and take immediate affirmative actions when students are showing signs of dropout.
 - b. Communities should have a literacy campaign to raise awareness of K-12 education.
2. Higher scholarships and better support for students from poor families.
3. Teachers should have a place they can stay in or near the school if they have to travel far from their home to teach. This was particularly important for female teachers.
 - a. They should have incentives for teaching in challenging and/or remote areas.
 - b. Their teaching should be monitored closely to make sure the students are not forced to pay informal fees or other bribes.
4. Schools in rural locations or in insecure places should have a mechanism to transport students back and forth to school. Lunch should also be provided and extra-curriculum activities should be provided to engage the students in a more practical level.
5. MoEYS should ensure there is at least one complete school in the community, especially when the next level school (upper secondary school) is far away from the current school in which students are currently enrolled.

MoEYS should ensure schools have Muslim and/or ethnic teachers to teach students from different religious or cultural backgrounds.

6. The counseling program should be established in each school to promote and enhance student learning by means of helping them dealing with their personal and emotional problems that can affect their studies.
7. Job providers, including factories, should strictly follow the age limitation for work in their factories.
 - a. Local authorities like village and commune chiefs should strictly follow the regulations. They should not issue fake or modified work paper allowing underage students to be employed in the factories.
 - b. Local job providers should be encouraged to prioritize giving employment to students who study and work part-time, not the dropout.

6.3. Limitations

This study was originally designed as an exploratory study combining both quantitative and qualitative research designs to explore lower secondary school dropout issues in urban and rural schools of Cambodia. In this regard, the findings of this study were limited in a few respects. First, only two sites (Phnom Penh and Kompong Speu) were considered for this study. This in nature limited its generalizability to a great degree, especially given the vividly changing nature of school dropouts across settings in Cambodia. More data across provinces are needed to provide a bigger and inclusive picture of school dropouts. Second, this study tested numerous factors associated with school dropout, using *t*-test, Chi-square, etc. But no sophisticated statistical tools, i.e., multiple regressions, were used to filter out factors that might have been weakly associated with school dropout and to identify potential factors explaining school dropout. Last but not definitely least, this study was not longitudinal in nature, studying about school dropout by student cohorts. Thus, it was hard to determine students' psychological state and behaviors before quitting school. Understanding their risky behaviors while they are in school and decision as to why they quit would better inform policy and practice.

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Appendixes

A. Questionnaire for dropouts



QUESTIONNAIRE (DROPOUTS)

School Name : _____

Code: _____

Date of Interview : _____

Dear Sir/Madam,

This questionnaire is prepared to collect primary data in respect of the research study on “School Dropout in Cambodia: An Exploratory Analysis of Urban-Rural Schools” commissioned to Royal University of Phnom Penh, the Faculty of Education by Korea International Cooperation Agency (KOICA). This is designed to analyze the causes of school drop-outs in rural and urban areas.

Hence, your honest response is of much importance. There are no ‘right’ or ‘wrong’ answers to each question that will be asked here. Your answers should be the ones that are ‘right’ for you. Your answers will be combined with others to make totals and averages in which no individual can be identified. All your answers will be kept confidential and will be used only for the purpose of the research. You can choose to whether or not join this study by signing the presented consent form.

Thank you

Section 1: About You

1. Gender 1. ☐ Male 2. ☐ Female
2. How old are you now? _____
3. How old were you when you quit school? _____
4. What ethnicity does your family carry?
 1. ☐ Khmer
 2. ☐ Chinese
 3. ☐ Muslim (Charm)
 4. ☐ Vietnamese
 5. ☐ Others (Please specify) _____
5. How was your health condition before you dropped out?
 1. ☐ Always got sick
 2. ☐ Often got sick
 3. ☐ Sometime got sick
 4. ☐ Rarely got sick
 5. ☐ Never got sick
6. I can do things for daily life as well as the others can.
 1. ☐ Strongly agree
 2. ☐ Agree
 3. ☐ Neutral /Don't Know
 4. ☐ Disagree
 5. ☐ Strongly disagree
7. I can do things for school life as well as the others can.
 1. ☐ Strongly agree
 2. ☐ Agree
 3. ☐ Neutral/Don't Know
 4. ☐ Disagree
 5. ☐ Strongly disagree

Section 2: Your Education

8. In general, did you like going to school?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
9. Did you attend a kindergarten?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
10. Did you parents unofficially enroll you in grade one when you were still too young for it?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
11. How old were you when you started grade one? _____
12. How many times did you ever repeat the grades?
1. ☐ Never 2. ☐ Once 3. ☐ Twice
4. ☐ Three times 5. ☐ Four times 6. ☐ Five or more
13. On average, in a month you attended in school, how many times were you absent from the class?
1. ☐ 0 2. ☐ 1-2 3. ☐ 3-4
4. ☐ 5-6 5. ☐ 7-8 6. ☐ 9 or more
14. Were you absent frequently before you finally quit?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
15. What were the reasons for those absences?

16. How do you feel now about not going to school anymore?
1. ☐ Better than before
2. ☐ The same as before
3. ☐ Worse than before
17. When you were in school, were you involved in any private classes?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
18. When you were still a student, how long/high did you wish to stay in school?
1. ☐ Stop schooling as soon as possible
2. ☐ Primary school
3. ☐ Lower-secondary school
4. ☐ Upper secondary school
5. ☐ University or college
19. How often did you finish the assigned homework given by your teacher?
1. ☐ Never 2. ☐ Rarely 3. ☐ Sometimes
4. ☐ Often 5. ☐ Always 6. ☐ Teacher never gave any homework

Section 3: Your Family

20. What is the highest level of education has your mother finished?

1. ☐ Never attended school 2. ☐ Primary school 3. ☐ Lower secondary school
4. ☐ Upper secondary school 5. ☐ University or college

21. What is the highest level of education has your father finished?

1. ☐ Never attended school
2. ☐ Primary school
3. ☐ Lower secondary school
4. ☐ Upper secondary school
5. ☐ University or college

22. What do your parents do?

Mother

- 1 ☐ Farmer
2 ☐ Worker at a factory, construction site or other places
3 ☐ Business people
4 ☐ Government officer
5 ☐ Staff of private sectors
6 ☐ Staff of NGO/DPs
7 ☐ Others (Please specify) _____

Father

- 1 ☐ Farmer
2 ☐ Worker at a factory, construction site or other places
3 ☐ Business people
4 ☐ Government officer
5 ☐ Staff of private sectors
6 ☐ Staff of NGO/DPs
7 ☐ Others (Please specify) _____

23. What is the highest education level did you parents/guardians expect you to complete?

1. ☐ Stop schooling as soon as possible 2. ☐ Primary school
3. ☐ Lower secondary school 4. ☐ Upper-secondary school
5. ☐ University or college 6. ☐ Don't know

24. Do your parents want you to do/be someone (e.g., a doctor or teacher) in the future?

1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No 3. ☐ Don't Know

25. Do your parents know level of education you need to get in order to obtain employment they

want you to have?

1. ☐ Yes

2. ☐ No

3. ☐ Don't Know

26. Do you want to do/be someone (e.g., a doctor or teacher) in the future?

1. ☐ Yes

2. ☐ No

3. ☐ Don't Know

27. Do you know level of education you need to get in order to obtain employment they want you to have?

1. ☐ Yes

2. ☐ No

3. ☐ Don't Know

28. On average, how much did your family earn a month before you quit school?

29. Did you quit school because you help your family to make more incomes?

1. ☐ Yes

2. ☐ No

30. Did you quit school because you help your family with household burden (cooking, cleaning, feeding, and taking family members)?

1. ☐ Yes

2. ☐ No

31. On average, how much pocket money did your parents/guardians give you to go to school?

_____ Riels

32. Which of the following items do you have at home? (You can tick more than one.)

	Yes	No
a. Television	☐	☐
b. Motorbike	☐	☐
c. Cellular phone	☐	☐
d. Car	☐	☐
e. Electricity	☐	☐
f. Piped Water	☐	☐
g. Fridge	☐	☐

33. Do you live with both of your parents?

1. ☐ Yes

2. ☐ No, I live with only my mum.

3. ☐ No, I live with only my dad.

4. ☐ No, I live with my relatives, not my parents.

34. Are your parents still married?

1. ☐ Yes

2. ☐ No, they were divorced.

3. ☐ Other options _____

35. How many brothers and sisters do you have? (excluding yourself) _____

36. What sibling order are you at?

☐ 1st

☐ 2nd

☐ 3rd

☐ 4th

☐ 5th

☐ Other (Please specify)_____

37. Do you have a sibling, either elder or younger, dropping out of schools before completing basic education or grade 9?

1. ☐ Yes

2. ☐ No

38. Before you dropped out, how often did you receive tutoring at home? (either from siblings or parents)

1. ☐ Never

2. ☐ Rarely

3. ☐ Sometimes

4. ☐ Often

5. ☐ Always

39. How much time did you help your parents at home per day when you were a student?

1. ☐ 0 – 0.5 hour

2. ☐ >0.5 – 1 hour

3. ☐ >1 – 2 hours

4. ☐ >2 – 3 hours

5. ☐ >3 – 5 hours

6. ☐ >5 hours

40. Did your help on family at home affect your study time?

1. ☐ Yes

2. ☐ No

41. How far is it from your house to school?

1. ☐ 0 – 0.5 km

2. ☐ 0.6 – 1 km

3. ☐ 1.1 – 2 km

4. ☐ 2.1 – 3km

5. ☐ 3.1 – 4km

6. ☐ 4.1 – 5km

7. ☐ 5.1 – 6km

8. ☐ 6.1 – 7km

9. ☐ More than 7 km

42. How did you travel to school, when you were at schools?

1. ☐ On foot

2. ☐ By bicycle

3. ☐ By motor bike

4. ☐ Other.....

43. How long does it take you to travel from home to school?

1. ☐ Less than 15 minute

2. ☐ 15 to 30 minutes

3. ☐ 31 to 45 minutes

4. ☐ 46 to 60 minutes

5. ☐ More than one hour

44. Did you feel safe to travel from home to school?

1. ☐ Completely safe

2. ☐ Mostly safe

3. ☐ Moderately safe

4. ☐ Slightly safe

5. ☐ Not safe at all

45. Did you have another accommodation near the school if it was far away from your home?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
46. Does your family members (including your father, mother, siblings, and relatives) involve in any forms of domestic violence?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No

Section 4: Your schooling experience

47. Did you have enough uniform for school?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
48. Did you have enough study materials (e.g. bag, textbook, books, pen and pencils)?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
49. When you attended school, how many friends did you have?
1. ☐ A lot 2. ☐ Some 3. ☐ A few 4. ☐ Almost no 5. ☐ No
50. How lonely did you feel at school?
1. ☐ Very lonely 2. ☐ Lonely 3. ☐ Somewhat lonely
4. ☐ Slightly lonely 5. ☐ Not lonely at all
51. What did you think about environment of your school, (clean, green and safe)?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Normal 4. ☐ Bad
5. ☐ Very bad
52. What did you think about classroom condition (space, air and light)?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Normal 4. ☐ Bad
5. ☐ Very bad
53. Was there any toilet at your school?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
54. Was toilet at your school are usable (has water, and is clean and secure)?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
55. What did you think about your teachers?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Normal 4. ☐ Bad
5. ☐ Very bad
56. What did you think about your school principal?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Normal 4. ☐ Bad
5. ☐ Very bad
57. During the last year of your schooling, how much did you need to pay for your teachers a day, on average... for private tutoring or unofficial fee like buying copy of tests or lesson?
☐ Not at all ☐ R100-500 ☐ R600-1,000 ☐ R1,100-2,000
☐ R2,100-5,000 ☐ R5100-10,000 ☐ R11,000-20,000 ☐ More than 20,000
58. What was your achievement at school in overall?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Fair 4. ☐ Poor 5. ☐ Very Poor

Section 5: Your community

59. Please tell if adult people in your community completed basic education (grade 9) or can read and write.

1. ☐ All 2. ☐ Most 3. ☐ Some 4. ☐ A few 5. ☐ None

60. Do families in your village experience domestic violence?

1. ☐ All 2. ☐ Most 3. ☐ Some 4. ☐ A few 5. ☐ None

61. Are there robberies, rape and killings happening in your village?

1. ☐ Never 2. ☐ Rarely 3. ☐ Sometime 4. ☐ Often 5. ☐ Always

62. Are there people doing illegal drug in your village?

1. ☐ All 2. ☐ Most 3. ☐ Some 4. ☐ A few 5. ☐ None

63. To what extent, do people in your community evolve in school enrollment?

1. ☐ Very Strongly 2. ☐ Strongly 3. ☐ Moderately 4. ☐ Slightly
5. ☐ Not at all

64. To what extent, do people in your community monitor school teaching and learning process?

1. ☐ Very Strongly 2. ☐ Strongly 3. ☐ Moderately 4. ☐ Slightly
5. ☐ Not at all

65. To what extent, do people in your community partake in school measures of preventing dropouts?

1. ☐ Very Strongly 2. ☐ Strongly 3. ☐ Moderately 4. ☐ Slightly
5. ☐ Not at all

Section 5: Scholarship and Supports

66. Do you receive any scholarship for your study?

1. ☐ Yes, from the government 2. ☐ Yes, NGOs or DPs
3. ☐ Yes, Others (please specify)_____ 4. ☐ No

67. If yes, how much scholarship do you receive per month?_____

68. Do you receive other supports (transport, study materials...) for your study?

1. ☐ Yes, from the government 2. ☐ Yes, NGOs or DPs
3. ☐ Yes, Others (please specify)_____ 4. ☐ No

69. If yes, please indicate things you get from scholarship and support

	Yes	No
Motorbike	☐	☐
Bicycle	☐	☐
Uniform	☐	☐
Bag	☐	☐

Books, pen and pencil

☐☐

Breakfast

☐☐

Section 6: Exploratory Question

70. What are the primary reasons of dropping out from school?

71. What will make you come back to school?

Thank you so much for your kind participation!

B. Questionnaire for non-dropouts



QUESTIONNAIRE (NON-DROPOUTS)

School Name : _____

Code: _____

Date of Interview : _____

Dear Sir/Madam,

*This questionnaire is prepared to collect primary data in respect of the research study on “**School Dropout in Cambodia: An Exploratory Analysis of Urban-Rural Schools**” commissioned to Royal University of Phnom Penh, the Faculty of Education by Korea International Cooperation Agency (KOICA). This is designed to analyze the causes of school drop-outs in rural and urban areas.*

Hence, your honest response is of much importance. There are no ‘right’ or ‘wrong’ answers to each question that will be asked here. Your answers should be the ones that are ‘right’ for you. Your answers will be combined with others to make totals and averages in which no individual can be identified. **All your answers will be kept confidential and will be used only for the purpose of the research.** You can choose to whether or not join this study by signing the presented consent form.

Thank you

Section 1: About You

1. Gender 1. ☐ Male 2. ☐ Female
2. How old are you now? _____
3. What ethnicity does your family carry? ☐ Khmer
☐ Chinese
☐ Muslim (Charm)
☐ Vietnamese

☐ Others (Please specify) _____

4. How is your health condition now?

- ☐ Always get sick
- ☐ Often get sick
- ☐ Sometime get sick
- ☐ Rarely get sick
- ☐ Never get sick

5. I can do things for daily life as well as the others can.

- ☐ Strongly agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral /Don't Know
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly disagree

6. I can do things for school life as well as the others can.

- ☐ Strongly agree
- ☐ Agree
- ☐ Neutral/Don't Know
- ☐ Disagree
- ☐ Strongly disagree

Section 2: Your Education

7. In general, do you like going to school?

1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No

8. Did you attend a kindergarten?

1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No

9. Did you parents unofficially enroll you in grade one when you were still too young for it?

1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No

10. How old were you when you started grade one? _____

11. How many times did you ever repeat the grades?

1. ☐ Never 2. ☐ Once 3. ☐ Twice
4. ☐ Three times 5. ☐ Four times 6. ☐ Five or more

12. On average, in a month you attended in school, how many times were you absent from the class?

1. ☐ 0 2. ☐ 1-2 3. ☐ 3-4
4. ☐ 5-6 5. ☐ 7-8 6. ☐ 9 or more

13. What were the reasons for those absences?

-
-
14. Are you involved in any private classes?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
15. How long/high do you wish to stay in school?
1. ☐ Stop schooling as soon as possible
2. ☐ Elementary school
3. ☐ Lower-secondary
4. ☐ Upper secondary
5. ☐ Until university
16. How often do you finish the assigned homework given by your teacher?
1. ☐ Never 2. ☐ Rarely 3. ☐ Sometimes
4. ☐ Often 5. ☐ Always 6. ☐ Teacher never gave any homework

Section 3: Your Family

17. What is the highest level of education has your mother finished?
1. ☐ Never attended school 2. ☐ Primary school 3. ☐ Lower Secondary School
4. ☐ Upper-secondary school 5. ☐ University or college
18. What is the highest level of education has your father finished?
1. ☐ Never attended school 2. ☐ Primary school 3. ☐ Lower Secondary School
4. ☐ Upper-secondary school 5. ☐ University or college
19. What do your parents do?

Mother

- 1 ☐ Farmer
- 2 ☐ Worker at a factory, construction site or other places
- 3 ☐ Business people
- 4 ☐ Government officer
- 5 ☐ Staff of private sectors
- 6 ☐ Staff of NGO/DPs
- 7 ☐ Others (Please specify) _____

Father

- 1 ☐ Farmer
- 2 ☐ Worker at a factory, construction site or other places

- 3 ☐ Business people
- 4 ☐ Government officer
- 5 ☐ Staff of private sectors
- 6 ☐ Staff of NGO/DPs
- 7 ☐ Others (Please specify) _____

20. What is the highest education level do you parents/guardians expect you to complete?

- 1. ☐ Stop schooling as soon as possible
- 2. ☐ Primary school
- 3. ☐ Lower secondary school
- 4. ☐ Upper-secondary school
- 5. ☐ University or college
- 6. ☐ Don't know

21. Do your parents want you to do/be someone (e.g., a doctor or teacher) in the future?

- 1. ☐ Yes
- 2. ☐ No
- 3. ☐ Don't Know

22. Do your parents know level of education you need to get in order to obtain employment they want you to have?

- 1. ☐ Yes
- 2. ☐ No
- 3. ☐ Don't Know

23. Do you want to do/be someone (e.g., a doctor or teacher) in the future?

- 1. ☐ Yes
- 2. ☐ No
- 3. ☐ Don't Know

24. Do you know level of education you need to get in order to obtain employment they want you to have?

- 1. ☐ Yes
- 2. ☐ No
- 3. ☐ Don't Know

25. On average, how much do your family earn a month? _____

26. Do you help your family to make more incomes?

- 1. ☐ Yes
- 2. ☐ No

27. Do you help your family with household burden (cooking, cleaning, feeding, and taking family members)?

- 1. ☐ Yes
- 2. ☐ No

28. On average, how much pocket money do your parents / guardian give you to go to school?
_____ Riels

29. Which of the following items do you have at home? (You can tick more than one.)

- | | Yes | No |
|-------------------|--------------------------|--------------------------|
| a. Television | ☐ | ☐ |
| b. Motorbike | ☐ | ☐ |
| c. Cellular phone | ☐ | ☐ |
| d. Car | ☐ | ☐ |

- e. Electricity ☐ ☐
- f. Piped Water ☐ ☐
- g. Fridge ☐ ☐

30. Do you live with both of your parents?

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No, I live with only my mum.
- ☐ No, I live with only my dad.
- ☐ No, I live with my relatives not my parents.

31. Are your parents still married?

5. ☐ Yes
6. ☐ No, they were divorced.
7. ☐ Other options _____

32. How many brothers and sisters do you have? (*excluding yourself*)

- ☐ 0 ☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4
- ☐ 5 ☐ 6 ☐ _____ (Please specify)

33. What sibling order are you at?

- ☐ 1st ☐ 2nd ☐ 3rd ☐ 4th ☐ 5th
- ☐ Other _____

34. Do you have a sibling, either elder or younger, dropping out of schools before completing basic education or grade 9?

1. ☐ Yes
2. ☐ No

35. How often do you receive tutoring at home? (either from siblings or parents)

1. ☐ Never
2. ☐ Rarely
3. ☐ Sometimes
4. ☐ Often
5. ☐ Always

36. How much time do you help your parents with household chores or business a day?

2. ☐ 0 – 0.5 hour 2. ☐ >0.5 – 1 hour 3. ☐ >1 – 2 hours
4. ☐ >2 – 3 hours 5. ☐ >3 – 5 hours 6. ☐ > 5 hours

37. Does your help on family household chores or business affect your study time?

1. ☐ Yes. 2. ☐ No

38. How far is it from your house to school?
- | | | |
|--|--|--|
| 1. ☐ 0 – 0.5 km | 2. ☐ 0.6 – 1 km | 3. ☐ 1.1 – 2 km |
| 4. ☐ 2.1 – 3km | 5. ☐ 3.1 – 4km | 6. ☐ 4.1 – 5km |
| 7. ☐ 5.1 – 6km | 8. ☐ 6.1 – 7km | 9. ☐ More than 7 km |
39. How do you travel to school?
- | | | |
|--|--|---|
| 1. ☐ On foot | 2. ☐ By bicycle | 3. ☐ By motor bike |
| 4. ☐ Other..... | | |
40. How long does it take you to travel from home to school?
1. ☐ Less than 15 minute
 2. ☐ 15 to 30 minutes
 3. ☐ 31 to 45 minutes
 4. ☐ 46 to 60 minutes
 5. ☐ More than one hour
41. Do you feel safe to travel from home to school?
1. ☐ Completely safe
 2. ☐ Mostly safe
 3. ☐ Moderately safe
 4. ☐ Slightly safe
 5. ☐ Not safe at all
42. Do you have another accommodation near the school if it is far away from your home?
- | | |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 1. ☐ Yes | 2. ☐ No |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|
43. Does your family members (including your father, mother, siblings, and relatives) involve in any forms of domestic violence?
- | | |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 1. ☐ Yes | 2. ☐ No |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|

Section 4: Your schooling experience

44. Do you have enough uniform for school?
- | | |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 1. ☐ Yes | 2. ☐ No |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|
45. Do you have enough study materials (e.g. bag, textbook, books, pen and pencils)?
- | | |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 1. ☐ Yes | 2. ☐ No |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|
46. How many friends do you have at school?
- | | | | | |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| 1. ☐ A lot | 2. ☐ Some | 3. ☐ A few | 4. ☐ Almost no | 5. ☐ No |
|-----------------------------------|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
47. How lonely do you feel at school?

1. ☐ Very lonely 2. ☐ Lonely 3. ☐ Somewhat lonely 4. ☐ Slightly lonely
5. ☐ Not lonely at all
48. What do you think about environment of school (clean, green and safe)?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Normal 4. ☐ Bad
5. ☐ Very bad
49. What do you think about classroom condition (space, air and light)?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Normal 4. ☐ Bad
5. ☐ Very bad
50. Is there any toilet at your school?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
51. Is toilet at your school are usable (has water, and is clean and secure)?
1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No
52. What do you think about your teachers?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Normal 4. ☐ Bad
5. ☐ Very bad
53. What do you think about your school principal?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Normal 4. ☐ Bad
5. ☐ Very bad
54. How much do you need to pay for your teachers a day, on average... for private tutoring or unofficial fee like buying copy of tests or lesson?
☐ Not at all ☐ R100-500 ☐ R600-1000 ☐ R1100-2000
☐ R2100-5000 ☐ R5100-10,000 ☐ R11,000-20,000 ☐ More than 20,000
55. What is your achievement at school in overall?
1. ☐ Very good 2. ☐ Good 3. ☐ Fair 4. ☐ Poor
5. ☐ Very Poor

Section 5: Your community

56. Please tell if adult people in your community completed basic education (grade 9) or can read and write.
1. ☐ All 2. ☐ Most 3. ☐ Some 4. ☐ A few 5. ☐ None
57. Do families in your village experience domestic violence?
1. ☐ All 2. ☐ Most 3. ☐ Some 4. ☐ A few 5. ☐ None
58. Are there robberies and killings happening in your village?

1. ☐ Never 2. ☐ Rarely 3. ☐ Sometime 4. ☐ Often 5. ☐ Always

59. Are there people doing drug in your village?

1. ☐ All 2. ☐ Most 3. ☐ Some 4. ☐ A few 5. ☐ None

60. To what extent, do people in your community evolve in school enrollment?

1. ☐ Very Strongly 2. ☐ Strongly 3. ☐ Moderately 4. ☐ Slightly
5. ☐ Not at all

61. To what extent, do people in your community monitor school teaching and learning process?

1. ☐ Very Strongly 2. ☐ Strongly 3. ☐ Moderately 4. ☐ Slightly
5. ☐ Not at all

62. To what extent, do people in your community partake in school measures of preventing dropouts?

1. ☐ Very Strongly 2. ☐ Strongly 3. ☐ Moderately 4. ☐ Slightly
5. ☐ Not at all

Section 6: Scholarship and Supports

63. Do you receive any scholarship for your study?

1. ☐ Yes, from the government 2. ☐ Yes, NGOs or DPs
3. ☐ Yes, Others (please specify) _____ 4. ☐ No

64. If yes, how much scholarship do you receive per month? _____

65. Do you receive any supports (transport and study materials...) for your study?

1. ☐ Yes, from the government 2. ☐ Yes, NGOs or DPs
3. ☐ Yes, Others (please specify) _____ 4. ☐ No

66. If yes, please indicate things you get from scholarship and support

	Yes	No
Motorbike	☐	☐
Bicycle	☐	☐
Uniform	☐	☐
Bag	☐	☐
Books, pens and pencils	☐	☐
Breakfast	☐	☐

Thank you so much for your kind participation!

C. Questionnaire for parents of dropouts



QUESTIONNAIRE (PARENTS OF THE DROPOUTS)

School Name : _____

Code: _____

Date of Interview : _____

Dear Sir/Madam,

*This questionnaire is prepared to collect primary data in respect of the research study on “**School Dropout in Cambodia: An Exploratory Analysis of Urban-Rural Schools**” commissioned to Royal University of Phnom Penh, the Faculty of Education by Korea International Cooperation Agency (KOICA). This is designed to analyze the causes of school drop-outs in rural and urban areas.*

Hence, your honest response is of much importance. There are no ‘right’ or ‘wrong’ answers to each question that will be asked here. Your answers should be the ones that are ‘right’ for you. Your answers will be combined with others to make totals and averages in which no individual can be identified. **All your answers will be kept confidential and will be used only for the purpose of the research.** You can choose to whether or not join this study by signing the presented consent form.

Thank you

Section 1: Demographic Information

1. Gender 1. ☐ Male 2. ☐ Female
2. Age _____ years old
3. What is your occupation?
 1. ☐ Farmer
 2. ☐ Worker at a factory, construction site or other places
 3. ☐ Business people

- 4. ☐ Government officer
- 5. ☐ Staff of private sectors
- 6. ☐ Staff of NGO/DPs
- 7. ☐ Others (Please specify) _____

4. What is your highest level of education attained?

- 1. ☐ Never attended school
- 2. ☐ Primary school drop-out
- 3. ☐ Primary school completion
- 4. ☐ Lower secondary school drop-out
- 5. ☐ Lower secondary school completion
- 6. ☐ Upper secondary school drop-out
- 7. ☐ Upper secondary school completion
- 8. ☐ University or higher drop-out
- 9. ☐ University or higher completion

5. Did you wish you could have studied higher?

- 1. ☐ Yes
- 2. ☐ No

6. How high would you study if you could do it as high as you could have?

- 1. ☐ Primary school
- 2. ☐ Lower secondary school.
- 3. ☐ Upper secondary school
- 4. ☐ Bachelor or higher

7. How much do your family earn per month?

8. How important is education for you?

- 1. ☐ Very important
- 2. ☐ Important
- 3. ☐ Moderately important
- 4. ☐ Little important
- 5. ☐ Not important at all

9. How many children do you have? _____

Order of children	Gender	Age	Grade	Schooling Status
a. First	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout
b. Second	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout
c. Third	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout
d. Fourth	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout
e. Fifth	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout
f. Sixth	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout
g. Seventh	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout
h. Eighth	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout
i. Ninth	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout
j. Tenth	☐ M ☐ F			☐ Completed ☐ Continuing ☐ Dropout

Note:

"Completed" means they have completed and graduate primary or lower secondary or higher secondary school and get an official certificate.

"Continuing" means they are still continuing their studies.

"Dropout" means they dropped out before completing primary or lower secondary or upper secondary school.

10. Among all the dropouts agent, who was the most influential agent on your child?

1. ☐ Themselves
2. ☐ The family
3. ☐ School
4. ☐ Others (Please specify) _____

11. Did your child's school keep you informed of your child study?

1. ☐ Yes
2. ☐ No

12. When your child dropped out, did the school put any effort in convincing you to send your child to go back to school?

1. Yes

If yes, what kinds of actions did school take? (Parents counseling, Student counseling, Home visit, others).....

2. No

13. What extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements on the reasons that your children quit schooling?

What extent do you agree or disagree with the following statements on the reasons that your children quit schooling?	Strongly Agree	Agree	Neutral	Disagree	Strongly Disagree
1. My child was old for his schooling.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2. My child had health problems.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3. My child performs poorly in his/her study (normally s/he received very low ranks in class).	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4. My child repeated the grades many times.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5. I am afraid my child might socialize with bad friends.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6. My family was/is poor we cannot afford their further education.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7. My family was/is poor so we need(ed) him/her to help with the family work.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
8. My family had financial problems (receiving loan from the bank or others) so we need him or her to do job to help generate more incomes.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
9. I felt that more education would not make much difference in their lives.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
10. Everyone in the village did not need much education to be rich or live happily.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
11. I do not think education system in Cambodia is good quality.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
12. My child needed to get married.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
13. My child needed to take care of other family members who are ill, aged or younger.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
14. My child wanted to quit as he/she felt isolated at school.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
15. My child was afraid to go to school as	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

teachers forced them to pay informal school fees.					
16. The teachers were often absent, so my kids did not learn much from going to school.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
17. Teachers did not teach my child well even though they came to school. They just taught to fulfill their duties.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
18. Teachers or principal normally used violence at school.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
19. I did not like the teacher or the school principal.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
20. My kid was afraid to go to school as there was bullying in school by other students.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
21. The school was far from home.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
22. I felt it was not safe to let my kid go to school as there were risks of crimes.	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

14. To what extent, do people in your community involve in school enrollment?

1. Very Strongly 2. Strongly 3. Moderately 4. Slightly 5. ☐ Not at all

15. To what extent, do people in your community monitor school teaching and learning process?

1. Very Strongly 2. Strongly 3. Moderately 4. Slightly 5. ☐ Not at all

16. To what extent, do people in your community partake in school measures of preventing dropouts?

1. Very Strongly 2. Strongly 3. Moderately 4. Slightly 5. ☐ Not at all

17. Did you child get scholarship from the government, NGOs or DPs?

1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No

18. If yes, did you think that scholarship and support was enough?

1. ☐ Yes 2. ☐ No

19. Among all the aforementioned influential predictors, could you give (three) most relevant predictors that you stopped your kid from schooling or your kid dropped out of school?

20. On what conditions will you send your children back to school?

Thank you so much for your kind participation!

D. Consent form



Consent Form

You are cordially invited to participate in a research study *“School Dropout in Cambodia: An Exploratory Analysis of Urban-Rural Schools”* commissioned to Royal University of Phnom Penh, the Faculty of Education by Korea International Cooperation Agency (KOICA). Your signature is required for participation. You must be at least 18 years of age (otherwise, your teacher/guardian) to give consent to participate in this study. You may also discuss with friends/family to decide on your participation. You will be given a copy of this form.

Description of the study

This is a study designed to analyze the causes of school drop-outs in rural and urban areas in Cambodia. You are requested to participate in this study by attending a 60-90 minute interview session and by sharing your views with our interviewer(s) with regard to the causes of dropout in Cambodia. You will be mainly asked about how you view the causes of dropout based on either your personal experience or perceptions towards the dropout issues in your school or community. We are not interested in your personal data or information beyond the scope of this research (as presented the questionnaire attached).

Our interviewers will guide you carefully to the questions of interest. You have the rights to ask questions and request further explanation if needed. The participation in this research is voluntary. You have the rights to withdraw at any time should you feel there is any inconvenience caused by the nature of the research. This research is not intended to showcase your background, perception or such to the public. All information is **highly confidential** and will not be used for other purposes other than what is stated in this research. Your privacy is highly respected and maintained.

Possible risks and discomforts

- A. In the interview, you may be asked about the problems related to your school, student learning and particularly reasons leading to school dropout. Some questions may reflect your negative/sensitive views that might affect your state of mind.

- B. You will be asked to provide personal information about yourself. But it is highly confidential.
- C. There are no anticipated potential risks to your physical and mental health.

Payment/compensation for participation

You will not be paid for your participation in this research study.

Potential benefits to subject, community and society

You will not get benefits from this study directly. BUT

- A) Findings of this research will give an overview of school dropout in Cambodia for improved policy and practice.
- B) You will have an opportunity to get familiar with the research project through your participation.
- C) You will have an opportunity to contribute to this research project to enhance the understanding of causes and/or challenges leading to school dropout.

If you have any questions or concerns about the research, please feel free to contact the research team leader Dr. Heng Kreng of the Center of Educational Research and Training, RUPP via krengheng@gmail.com or 077 777 934.

Signature of participant/guardian

Signature of interviewer



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